

George Douglas Papers family reading edition

Volume VIII

Folder 7 poems and other writings

Version 2.0

September 2026

Prepared for Volney Douglas

From scans supplied by Abilene Christian University

Special Collections and Archives

A readable version in plain English, with uncertainties and damaged passages marked.

This volume accounts for all 133 scan pages of source 10. It belongs to a set covering 932 scan pages in ten source PDFs. This AI-assisted contribution is offered for review and correction.

Reading this volume

Preparation and independence

Prepared for Volney Douglas with AI assistance in September 2026. Every new scan page received an initial visual reading, with selected enlargement, rotation, contrast adjustment and comparison against related passages within the source collection. Local Apple Vision OCR was run at four orientations on all 545 new pages as a reading aid. OCR agreement alone did not establish a reading. The other agent's transcription was excluded as a source for this addition. Reference and family readings of the new pages were prepared together from the scans; they are not independent of each other. No independent human verification or ACU endorsement is claimed. The earlier version 1.1 has its own disclosed comparison history, preserved in the previous guide and review records.

Reference and family editions

The annotated reference edition preserves readable original wording, spelling, grammar and abbreviations. Ordinary prose wrapping may be reflowed; poem lines and ledger groups are retained. Capitalization, punctuation and word division sometimes require judgment. Superscripts are generally lowered; raised numbers in the convivial journal are retained. Underlining and decorative marks are not systematically encoded. This is a direct reading transcript, not a facsimile or fully diplomatic edition. The family edition modernizes wording and explains abbreviated forms where secure. Very damaged passages sometimes receive an explicitly identified fragmentary reading rather than an invented continuous text. Financial figures remain as read and are not silently reconciled.

Uncertainty and interventions

Double square brackets identify editorial intervention. `[[word?]]` is a tentative reading; `[[illegible]]` marks unread writing, with no implied word count. `[[lost: description]]` records missing material and `[[obscured: description]]` records an obstruction. `[[deleted: text]]` and `[[inserted: text]]` distinguish readable revisions. `[[separate block: description]]`, `[[blank]]` and other descriptive markers explain layout or non-textual material. Original single brackets and question marks remain part of the source. A gap is not filled solely to make a fluent sentence or to match a related copy.

Order and evidence

The reference volumes retain PDF scan order. Editorial notes link displaced continuations and clearer related versions. The family edition also retains source-page locators, with reading-order guidance beside the relevant text. Later identifying slips remain distinct from the manuscript and may disagree with it. A name in an account does not establish kinship, ownership or parentage. Poems may use fictional speakers, aliases, satire and imagined events. Letters preserve their writers' assertions, rumors and opinions, including offensive historical language; a transcript does not verify those statements.

Locators and corrections

A page ID such as 09-003 means source 09, PDF scan page 3, counting the cover as page 1. A block ID such as 09-003-P02 identifies the second transcript block. These locators are not original manuscript page numbers. Earlier IDs are unchanged. New uncertainty IDs append U001, U002 and so on to their source-page ID. Please propose corrections with the locator, existing wording, proposed wording and supporting image evidence. The original scans remain authoritative.

Source credit

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Source record

George Douglas Papers Folder 7 - Poems Etc.pdf

SHA-256: 3cda436be7bee32202e7103029824d0252d162d88303988be716c2f558dcf4a2

Scan 001 10-001

Repository cover: Folder 7, Poems, Etc.

Abilene Christian University, Digital Commons @ ACU. George Douglas Papers, Folder 7: Poems, Etc.
The repository lists 1860, but the folder contains material from other years as well. This page is the digital repository cover.

Scan 002 10-002

Lumber ledger: inside cover and index A–E

Inside cover: “Lumber for own use, Page 22.” Faint pencil words and figures are partly unreadable.

Account index (ledger page numbers):

A: no entry.

B: Bledsoe, John — 21; Birkhead, L. — 25.

C: *[[Crumtee?]]* — 11; Cannon — 12; Cash sales — 7.

D: *[[Dowdy?]]* — 17; Dunn — 20.

E: Ellis & White — 87; Ellis — 16.

Scan 003 10-003

Account index F–O, calculations, and a medicinal note

Account index, ledger page 2:

F: no entry.

G: Gibson, J. G. — 8; Goodloe — 25.

H: Hatter — 13.

Separate pencil calculation: 74 / 4957; 65 / 4802; 65 / *[[4492?]]*; *[[208?]]* / 14251; 113*[[80?]]*;
28*[[71?]]*.

Ledger page 3:

[[Riley?]], Charles — 19.

M: Morris — 14; Moffet — 11.

O: Odom — 9.

Separate historical medicinal note: “Lactophytin,” five grains before each meal, followed by *[[after?]]*.

Two other faint lines include “No 30” and “No 12” but cannot be read securely.

Scan 004 10-004

Account index P–W

Account index, ledger page 4:

Payne — 6.

James *[[Partee?]]* — 18.

George Porter — 50.

Renfroe — 10.

Milton Rawlins — 20.

Robinson — 90–91.

Stevenson — 15.

Sweatt — 26.

Samuel Lee — 29.

Ledger page 5:
Winniford — 10.
C. Winniford — 27.

Scan 005 10-005

Payne's fencing order and cash lumber sales, January 13, 1872

Ledger page 6. January 13, 1872: Payne's account.
700 feet of fencing ordered/reserved ("Engaged").
Cash credit: 10.00.
February *[[1873?]]*: *[[credit for boards?]]*; "75" and further unclear wording; 7.50.
"Filled in full."

Ledger page 7. January 13, 1872: cash sales.
96 feet of sheeting — 1.40.
600 feet, C. f. — 15.00.
108 feet of scantling — 2.70.
64 feet, C. f. — 1.55.
179 feet of sheeting — 2.69.

Reading note. Scantling means small structural lumber. "C. f." remains unexpanded. Amounts and quantities are transcribed, not recalculated.

Scan 006 10-006

Gibson and Odom lumber accounts, 1872–1873

Ledger page 8: J. J. Gibson.
January 9, 1872: 570 feet, c. f., carried from the "Old Book." Credit: 12.00.
February 1873: 300 feet, c. f., sold to *[[Coleman?]]* for Gibson by *[[Tom?]]*. Credit: 7.50.
Ledger page 9: Odom.
January 9, 1873: 300 feet, c. f., cash: 7.50.

Reading note. The abbreviation "c. f." remains as written. Account names do not establish family relationships.

Scan 007 10-007

Renfro, Winniford, and *[[Crumpton?]]* lumber entries; Moffet's purchases

Ledger page 10: Renfro.
January 9, 1873: 150 feet, c. f. — 3.75; credit — 1.50.
Winniford, July 1873: 185 feet, c. boxing — 4.62.
Ledger page 11: *[[Crumpton?]]*, January 8, 1873.
892 feet of cottonwood — 22.30; cash credit — 22.30.
Moffet's account:
One *[[lot?]]* of an unreadable item — 1.00.
Four yards of linen at 25 — 1.00.
One pair of gloves — 0.50.
One pair of black hose — 0.35.
One corset — 1.00.
Twelve yards of checked fabric at 35 — 4.20.

Ten yards of calico — 1.25.

Separate figure: $36\frac{3}{4}$.

Reading note. Amounts are preserved without recalculation. “c. f.” and “c. boxing” remain unexpanded.

Scan 008 10-008

Cannon and Hatter accounts; a small land sketch and arithmetic

Ledger page 12: Cannon.

January 10, 1873: *[[837?]]* feet, c. f., “by Book” — 20.90; cash credit — 20.90.

January 11, 1873: 600 feet, c. f. — 15.00; cash credit — 15.00.

Ledger page 13: Hatter.

January 10, 1873: 102 feet, c. f. — 2.55; cash credit — 2.55.

Upside-down additions: a small land sketch, labeled “Plat for 15 acres in S E C of W. J. *[[unreadable name]]*.” Visible sketch figures include 268 and 25. Separate arithmetic on page 12 includes 975; 2685, 3330, 2352, *[[915?]]*, 1377, 578, 799; and *[[1100?]]*, *[[626?]]*, 1084, 775, 309.

The page 13 calculation reads: 25; 775 / 1700; 309 / 626; 1084 / 1074; 626; 1710.

Reading note. The scratch calculations are recorded, not solved or attributed to the adjacent customers.

Scan 009 10-009

Morris and Stevenson accounts; faint pencilled additions

Ledger page 14: Dr. Morris, January 10, 1873.

288 feet of sheeting — 4.32. “Placed to mill account.”

Ledger page 15: January *[[14?]]*, 1873. Sold to J. Stevenson: *[[oak?]]* herring; two feet at 3.00, amount *[[0.06?]]*. A further entry starts “5 *[[oak?]]*” but is not readable throughout.

Separate upside-down purchases: 12 yards of checked fabric at 30, amount 3.60; 18 yards of calico; four yards of *[[lawn?]]*; one yard of an unreadable material. Other figures overlap and remain unresolved.

A separate faint passage, apparently verse, occupies much of page 14. Only scattered words such as “And,” “Each,” and “hills” are securely visible. A possible name, *[[A. Morrow?]]*, appears below. The passage cannot yet be presented as a continuous reading.

Reading note. The verse and several pencil calculations still need examination of a better image or the original.

Scan 010 10-010

Polk Ellis and Dowdy lumber accounts, 1873

Ledger page 16: Polk Ellis.

February 27, 1873: 220 feet of sheeting; credit — 5.00.

Ledger page 17: Dowdy’s account.

January 15, 1873: 300 feet of fencing — 7.50.

January, day left blank, 1873: 132 feet of *[[scantling?]]* — 3.30. “Placed to mill account.”

Scan 011 10-011

Lumber accounts and an invitation in verse

Ledger page 18: James *[[Parr?]]*, January 23, 1873.

304 feet of c. boxing — 7.60. Placed to the mill account.

Separate verse, lightly modernized:

Why don't you come, gentle fair?

The days pass slowly by.

My heart is oppressed with anxious care;

How slowly the moments fly!

Your pleasant smiles and *[[winning?]]* ways

Would surely dispel the gloom.

[[Even?]] the fire would blaze more brightly;

[[The next line is unclear.]]

Then come and grace our social board,

And share our fireside joys.

We will give you a cordial welcome *[[gladly?]]*.

[[The last line cannot be read fully.]]

Ledger page 19: Charles *[[Riley?]]*, January 22, 1873.

302 feet of sheeting — 4.53. Placed to the mill account.

Reading note. The invitation's writer and intended visitor are unknown. The family reading follows the apparent revised wording and leaves unresolved lines marked.

Scan 012 10-012

A lumber donation to the church at Hutchins; Dunn and Bledsoe accounts

Ledger page 20: Milton Rawlins.

February 28, 1873: M. Rawlins donated 300 feet of sheeting to the church at Hutchins.

Tom Dunn, March 22, 1873: 175 feet, c. f. — 4.35.

Ledger page 21: John Bledsoe.

March 26, 1873: 2,000 feet, c. f., through Schneider — 50.00. Placed to the mill account.

Scan 013 10-013

Lumber for own use and entries since settlement, 1873

Ledger page 22, identified in the cover index as lumber for the owner's use:

January 25, 1873 — 115.

March 5 — 240, c. f.; March 14 — 466; March 15 — 410; March 17 — 500; March 18 — 600; March 20 — 476; March 21 — 500; March 22 — 458; March 27 — 460; March 28 — 400; March 29 — 500;

March 31 — 550.

April 1 — 500; April 3 — 550.

Ledger page 23, "Since Settlement":

May 10, 1873 — 500, c. f.

July 11 — 578, scantling; July 23 — 566, ditto.

August 6 — 482, sycamore; August 9 — 750, c. f.; August 13 — 350, c. boxing.

Figures below: 3229; 185 with unreadable wording; 3314.

October 15: 350, ash flooring.

An outlined calculation dated March 10, 1873 includes 600 feet of *[[unreadable description]]* fencing;

[[dressed?]] and other unclear words; 450; 650 feet of c. fence, with "between Red Oak"; 1600; "Half due mill"; and *[[5 600?]]*.

Reading note. These are ledger quantities and scratch figures, not a reconstructed total. Abbreviations and doubtful amounts remain marked.

Scan 014 10-014

Birkhead and R. H. Goodloe accounts, March 1873

Ledger page 24 is blank.

Ledger page 25: Birkhead, March 21, 1873.

2,000 feet, c. f.; cash credit — 50.00.

Separate calculation: 40.14, 22.50, 62.64; “32” beside it.

R. H. Goodloe, March 22, 1873.

1,000 feet, c. f. — 25.00; cash credit — 24.50.

March 29, 1873: another cash credit — 0.50.

Scan 015 10-015

Bell, Sweatt, Samuel Lee, and Ephriam Winniford accounts

Ledger page 26: J. W. Bell, March 31, 1873.

Several lumber entries are crossed through or faint. Visible figures include 200 feet, c. f., *[[4.55?]]* and 6.00; 185 with unclear wording; and 2182. A nearby calculation reads 759, 71, 830.

D. J. Sweatt: 200 feet, c. f. — 5.00.

Samuel Lee: 92 feet of strips — 2.32; cash credit — 1.36.

Separate calculation: 92, 2, 184, *[[49?]]*, 2.33.

Ledger page 27: Ephriam Winniford.

“Worked 13 days,” with *[[August?]]* 15 nearby; March 28, 1874.

April 29, 1874: paid E. Winniford 8.30; due 9.00.

“Paid by note,” September 12, 1874.

Reading note. This records a work and payment account. It does not establish a family relationship, and the work-period dates are not fully clear.

Scan 016 10-016

Faint verse draft on youth, affection, and passing time

This two-page draft is too faint and heavily revised for a reliable continuous modern version.

Page 28 has references to sunny woodlands, fields, flowers, and an overhanging shore. Most connecting words are unreadable.

Page 29 contains clearer phrases about hearts that are “brave” and “fondly” devoted, “the long gone, perished ages,” “Love, Happiness,” and “after years.” It contrasts youth with growing “old, gaunt, and bald,” and includes a “gentle smile / That bids the care of day depart, depart.” The closing lines mention returning *[[home?]]* again, but cannot be fully recovered.

The exact readable fragments, tentative words, and gaps are retained in the reference transcript.

Reading note. This is an account of legible fragments, not a reconstruction of the missing poem. Better imaging or examination of the original may improve it. For a continuous related poem, read 10-059, 10-058, then 10-055. The faint draft has differences, so the versions remain distinct.

Scan 017 10-017

Verse on death, memory, and the generations that follow

The first manuscript page of this spread is largely unreadable. It mentions hills, wreaths of flowers, midnight, and thoughts of things that might have been.

The facing page is more readable. These scenes and thoughts awaken us, and we forget the Indigenous person's grave and the white person's tomb. They lived and loved, knew joys and follies, yet death broke the cherished bonds that held them to life. The draft then speaks of idle mourning over their revered remains and of desecrating tombs raised by affection to honor and guard the dead. Part of the revised wording remains unclear.

Soon we will pass away, leaving *[[unreadable wording]]* behind to tell what we were: a single trace. Like fragile spider silk carried by the wind, we will go, and no one may ever mark where we fall. This busy race will have no time to pause when we are gone. The young and cheerful will laugh on, led by life's *[[unreadable wording]]*. The final revised line cannot be read securely.

Reading note. This family reading summarizes the readable portion and quotes only surviving wording, with an ellipsis for unresolved text. The reference transcript preserves the gaps and revisions. For a continuous related poem, read 10-059, 10-058, then 10-055. The faint draft has differences, so the versions remain distinct.

Scan 018 10-018

Further verse revisions and a page of arithmetic

The verse continues in a heavily revised, faint draft. Most lines are not recoverable as connected sentences. A darker insertion reads “a busy life’s work still half undone,” near a reference to death. Other fragments mention youth and “to come.” No author or date is supplied.

The facing page contains arithmetic. Visible groups include *[[635?]] / [[6.08?]]*; 760 with 12938*[[8?]]*, followed by 760, 2738 / 369, and 1300 / 950; then 56460, 5, 282300, 3; and a division-like arrangement beginning 20)846900(44, followed by *[[760?]]*, 86, 70, *[[169?]]*, 25, 140, and *[[96?]]*.

Reading note. The poem remains a partial reading; the calculations are not identified as money or assigned to a person. For a continuous related poem, read 10-059, 10-058, then 10-055. The faint draft has differences, so the versions remain distinct.

Scan 019 10-019

A faint poem, possibly headed “Invocation”

This faint poem may be titled “Invocation.” Readable fragments include “a cold bleak” opening, a gale, howling, the sky, friendship, “one heart,” words apparently about a heart “beating for you,” and “speak peace.” These fragments suggest an appeal for comfort, but the connecting lines remain too uncertain for a continuous modern version.

Separate arithmetic includes 2200 / 750, 2214 / *[[25?]]*, 4414 / *[[775?]]* at the top of the right page, and *[[212?]]*, 28, *[[240?]]* below the left-page verse.

Reading note. The description of an appeal for comfort is a tentative interpretation of fragments, not a recovered full text.

Scan 020 10-020

An alliterative prose exercise using words beginning with A

A literary exercise uses repeated words beginning with A. Legible phrases include “amiable and affable,” “Allan, an anchorite,” “an abrupt address,” “admiration,” “admonition,” “affinity,” “adumbrating an attachment,” “an amicable” passage, “affection,” “assemblage,” “attentive audition,” and “annunciation, awakening an affectionate agitation.” Many connecting words and the heading remain unresolved. This is not currently readable as a complete story. The reference transcript records the surviving words in order.

Reading note. The apparent personal names belong to an unfinished or copied literary exercise; no biographical relationship is inferred.

Scan 021 10-021

Faint verse with references to dreams, silence, and desolation

The first page remains very faint. It includes “to dream,” “to gaze,” and fragments concerning love and changing scenes.

On the facing page, no answer comes from the speaker’s surroundings. Silence and gloom are constant companions. The speaker feels lonely, as though sunk to the sea’s deepest depths, where the *[[uncoffined?]]* dead lie decaying. The poem asks when this dreadful desolation will end, binding the soul in suffering. The last question and the line about a new morning remain incomplete.

A clearer related version is Bachelor’s Lament at 10-047, but its wording differs from this draft.

Reading note. This page needs a better image or examination of the original. The reference transcript records the visible fragments and gaps. A clearer related version of Bachelor’s Lament is at 10-047. It helps explain the poem but is not an exact replacement for this draft.

Scan 022 10-022

“We are growing old together Jim”

We are growing old together, Jim.

The years come swiftly on.

Our hair is growing gray and thin;

The days of our youth are gone.

Some thirty years have taken flight

Since you and I were born.

We have gathered flowers, fair and bright,

And felt the piercing thorn.

Where is our gentle *[[Mary?]]* now,

Who accepted our early *[[pledge?]]*?

What sorrows *[[might she know?]]*?

What cares may surround us both?

Perhaps beside a rippling stream,

Where murmuring waters flow,

They live a *[[peaceful?]]* life

That we may never know.

On the facing page:

[[The opening line is unclear.]]

With all our boyhood's games,
 The bat and ball—but never mind,
 Their names are not forgotten.
 The sunny scenes of long ago
 Are hidden by clouds and gloom,
 And many a winter's icy *[[blast?]]*
 Has nipped the summer's bloom.
 We cannot follow where they have gone;
 Our paths have separated widely.
 But in the Great Beyond
 Nothing can divide us.

The final stanza recalls former companions and says that some have fallen and some sleep, but several words are too faint to read.

Reading note. This is a modern reading of an unsigned poem, retaining uncertain passages. It is not assumed to describe George's own life or a relative named Jim. See 10-023 for the ending.

Scan 023 10-023

"Enough—we too must go": the ending of the poem to Jim

Our golden dreams of a better time
 Have gone with the shining past.
 Those rapturous visions of *[[youth?]]*
 Were all too bright to last.
 Why we remain to tell the story,
 We may not ask to know.
 Enough—we feel life's piercing pains.
 Enough—we too must go.

Reading note. Lightly modernized from the final two stanzas of the poem on 10-022.

Scan 024 10-024

Undated arithmetic on manuscript pages 46 and 49

Two manuscript pages contain undated calculations rather than a narrative or named account.
 Page 46: 260130; 1120644; 2234295; a division-like arrangement 3.6)1569(64066; then 30876, *[[327467?]]*, 2584, 1429. A neighboring group reads 1244, 907, 1244, followed by unclear figures.
 Page 49: 2688, 962, 1726, 1144; 2)2870; 1435, 1557, 10045, 7175, 7175, 1435, 2234295.
 A separate group reads 1344, 200, 1144, 1344, 2488, 1244.

Reading note. These figures are preserved as written/read. They are not labeled as money, and the calculations have not been silently corrected.

Scan 025 10-025

Verse beside a rocky shore; faint writing and arithmetic

A darker verse begins "Lo! where yon lone *[[willow?]]*" and refers to a rocky shore, spreading *[[blossoms?]]*, and spending hours there as the day declines. Several words are unresolved, so a complete

modern version cannot yet be supplied.

Fainter writing below includes “23 1873,” with no securely readable month. The facing page has a heading beginning “Life’s Stormy” and more very faint verse.

Arithmetic below the verse reads *[[190?]]*; then 140, 2, 280, 70, 350, 490, 840, 187, 1027. A neighboring calculation reads 140, 3½, 420, 70, 490. Isolated figures include *[[120?]]* and 169.

Reading note. The verse remains partly unreadable. The numeric workings are transcribed without claiming a corrected result.

Scan 026 10-026

A poem of bereavement beside property calculations

The poem recalls friends of the speaker’s youth, pale figures beckoning toward the shore of death, and a mound beneath a weeping willow. Its clearer closing lines say that the *[[darling?]]* of the speaker’s heart is sleeping there and call on the death angel to “gather me there to sleep as well.” The beginning and some connecting lines are unreadable.

The facing page contains property notes: *[[wagons?]]* 100, *[[buggy?]]* 35, and faint entries for *[[a horse?]]* and *[[mules?]]*. Figures include 51235, 148, 36435, 18217, 2275, *[[175?]]*.

A lower list reads 300 horses, 74 hogs, 120 cattle, and 40 followed by unclear wording; further entries are faint. A calculation includes 510, 148, 362, and half of 362 shown as 181. Nearby figures include 142, 71, 120, 73, and *[[58095?]]*.

Reading note. The poem expresses bereavement but does not identify the deceased. Inventory figures must not be treated as animal counts without further evidence. A clearer related version of Bachelor’s Lament is at 10-047. It helps explain the poem but is not an exact replacement for this draft.

Scan 027 10-027

Personal-property division and an undated purchase list

Manuscript page 56:

51235 — “Personal P,” probably personal property.

148 — debt.

36435 — left.

18217 — one half.

2275 — one eighth.

The amounts are copied without inserting decimal points or correcting the calculation.

Manuscript page 57: an undated purchase list, with many items crossed out. Legible entries include two unreadable items priced 1.25 and 1.75; one small item with an unclear description; nine yards of an unclear material at 12, amount 1.08; six yards of jeans fabric at 60, amount 3.60; paper; a heavily crossed item followed by “Bk”; a pair of an unclear item; nails; and one box of an unreadable item. Marginal words and several further figures remain unresolved.

Reading note. The division does not identify an estate or beneficiaries. Crossed purchase entries are not assumed to be canceled transactions.

Scan 028 10-028

Salt, coffee, porter, and miscellaneous calculations

The left page is mostly arithmetic. Readable groups include 4983, 4983, *[[485?]]*, 249, 5727, 5240, 10967 divided by two, and 5483; then 36.64, 8, 22, 66.64, 7.50, 59.14; 54.83, 15.75, 39.08; and 54.83, 35.75, 19.8. Sideways words include “Pirates,” “from *[[Sinclair?]]*,” and “Geiss Bk for” followed by an unreadable word. Another isolated word may be *[[Bethlehem?]]*.

The right page lists: one “Bk” of salt, 4.60; coffee, 20.25; porter, 7.50; one bag and an unclear item, 2.00. Figures beneath read 36.35, 25, 36.60, 18.70, *[[55.30?]]*.

Further calculation groups read: 16967, *[[8220?]]*, *[[57.47?]]*, *[[4?]]*, 70, *[[64.57?]]*; 63.85, 57.47, 6.38; 54.83, 36.50, 18.33; 18.33, 19.8, *[[37.41?]]*; and 43.42, 37.4, *[[6.35?]]*, 7.00, followed by an unclear figure.

Reading note. These are draft calculations, not a verified financial statement. Abbreviations and possible names remain unresolved.

Scan 029 10-029

Waxahachie pen trials and scratch arithmetic

The writer practiced “Waxahachie,” the letter W, and “Scribbling,” and also wrote “Ellis County” and “Texas.”

The rest of manuscript page 62 contains scratch arithmetic. Legible groups include 1040, *[[945?]]*, *[[24?]]*, 6.35; 44.00 divided by two; 44, 55, 220; 68 / 20, 17, 37, 15, 185, 370, 555, 20, 650, 925, 1040, 115, 97, 5, 485, 555, 1040, 134. A right-hand group includes 50, 400, 370, 770, 90, 5, 850, *[[97?]]*, 1120, 115, and 1430, with several overlapping figures unresolved.

The facing manuscript page, numbered 65, is blank.

Reading note. The repeated place names are pen practice; no move, residence, or transaction is inferred.

Scan 030 10-030

Two land sketches, one labeled J. D. Orr

Two survey sketches occupy the spread.

The left is labeled J. D. Orr and *[[50?]]* acres. It has a top edge marked 548, a right edge marked 372, a bottom edge marked 813, and sloping left edges marked 150 and *[[241?]]*. Bearing lines read north 44½ degrees east and north 13 degrees west.

The right sketch has an irregular left edge and a rectangular notch on the right. Labels include 1344, 200, *[[north 20 degrees west?]]*, *[[544?]]*, *[[525?]]*, north 14 degrees west, 1760, 950, 841, 1344, 841, and *[[1606?]]*.

Reading note. These are descriptions of the drawn plats, not replacement surveys. The scan is necessary to examine the exact geometry. The J. D. Orr label does not by itself establish ownership.

Scan 031 10-031

“Fear not my Little One”

A short verse begins, “Fear not, my little one.” It mentions clouds or darkness around the dwelling, a storm, light, and perfume. Much of the connecting wording is too faint to recover, so no complete modern version is supplied.

Reading note. The address to a “little one” is literary wording and does not identify a particular family member.

Scan 032 10-032

An irregular survey sketch and an area calculation

Manuscript page 74 contains an irregular survey sketch with internal diagonal lines. Visible labels are 230, 400, 545, and *[[367?]]*.

Page 75 contains a calculation: 785, 805, 3925, 6280; then a long-division arrangement beginning 5646)631925(11, followed by 5646, 6732, 5646, 10865, 1129, and 427.

Reading note. The diagram is described, not converted into a replacement survey. The source gives no clear name or date on this spread.

Scan 033 10-033

Survey courses using an elm and a branch as landmarks

A stake on the north line of an unreadable property or reference. An elm, 14 inches in diameter, lies north *[[21?]]* degrees east, nine varas away.

Then north 30 degrees east, 230 varas, followed by an unclear abbreviation.

Down the branch, 400 varas, south 60 degrees east.

Then 545 varas, north 30 degrees east, on the north side of the branch. A final tree or landmark description includes “7 in E” but is incomplete.

The facing page adds three courses:

686, south 40 degrees west.

180, south 30 degrees east.

475, south 60 degrees west.

Reading note. These are historical field-note fragments, not a complete modern property description.

Scan 034 10-034

A hackberry landmark, Sublett reference, and survey arithmetic

The left-page notes begin at the southwest corner of an unclear named property. A hackberry is south 40 degrees east, $3\frac{3}{4}$ *[[varas?]]* away. Another entry reads north 30 degrees east, four followed by an unclear unit or word. A separate line says “1760 varas, Sublett’s E.”

The facing page contains a divided survey sketch, with labels including 1344, *[[173?]]*, 180, 112, 1770, and 278; other marks remain unclear.

Calculation groups include 112, 180, 1301, 2688, 1587, 795, 6835, 12085, 9101; a division-like arrangement 5646)102665(18, followed by 5646, 46205, 45168, *[[1037?]]*; and a separate group 173, 18, 54, 245.

Reading note. The named landmark and Sublett reference are useful research clues, but the fragment does not establish ownership or an exact location.

Scan 035 10-035

Purchases from Bates and Ellis & White, February–April 1874

Manuscript page 80. February 12, 1874: bought one side of leather from Bates, *[[9.00?]]*.

Separate upside-down calculations include 880, 580, 300, 1760, 3, 5280 divided by two, 1320, 6600, 2, 7800, 2, 15600, 3900, 19500, 14340, 33840, *[[14825?]]*, 48625; and 405, *[[261?]]*, 907, *[[1235?]]*, 955,

5, 4775, 655, 14340, 37, 4, 148.

Manuscript page 81. February 18, 1874: bought from Ellis & White:

Two pairs of hames — 2.50.

One pair of shoes — 2.25.

Five yards, “No 5” — 0.84.

Half a dozen buckles — 0.12.

“By Elbert Winniford”; total shown, 5.71.

April 25, 1874:

Three yards of hickory fabric at 20 — 0.60.

Three yards of the same at 18 — 0.54.

One hat — 4.00.

One pencil — 0.10.

One daybook — 0.10.

One handkerchief — 0.40.

One shirt bosom — 0.60.

One box of collars — 0.25.

Tobacco — 1.00.

Total — 7.59.

Reading note. Hames are parts of a horse’s harness. “Hickory” here is the fabric sold by the yard. No family relationship is inferred from the intermediary’s name.

Scan 036 10-036

Household goods, clothing materials, honey, and a payment, 1874

June 3, 1874:

One tin bucket; one block-tin pan.

Eleven pounds of *[[soda?]]* — 2.43.

Two yards of denim at 25 — 0.50.

Six and a half yards of *[[cassimere?]]* at 1.00 — 6.50.

Three spools — 0.25; coat buttons — 0.20; one box of collars — 0.25; one grease box — 0.30; one comb — 0.40; dress buttons — 0.10.

October 1, 1874:

Two buckets at 35 — 0.70; five yards of calico — 0.62; two tin dishes — 0.25; sugar — 1.50. A figure of 13.61 appears below.

June 23, 1874: paid Ellis & White 10.00. A further entry reads 12¾ pounds of honey at 12½ — 1.58.

Scratch calculation groups:

1121, 336, 785, 545; 1330 divided by two, 665, 200, 133000; 549, 785, 2745, 4392, 3843, 430965; 965, 475, 4825, 6755, 3860, 458375.

A neighboring group reads 571, 759, 1350, 2680, 2399, 5079, 1152, 3927, 4095, 168.

Reading note. Quantities, prices, and figures are preserved as read; doubtful product names remain marked.

Scan 037 10-037

Overlapping arithmetic and a faint purchase list

Manuscript page 84 contains calculations beginning 133000, 430965, 458375, followed by long division written as 5644)1022340(18 and the figures 5646, 45774, 45188, 5860.

Neighboring groups read 2680, 336, 2344, 1569, 775, 630, 180, 845; then 1504, 678, 846, 475, 371.

Page 85 has a faint purchase or quantity list covered by darker calculations. About eight lines cannot be read securely. The darker groups include 761, 619, 142; 903 divided by two, 451; 151, 155, 306; 1567, 150, 1387; 1567, 451, 1567, 7835, 6268; then 5646)706717(125, 5646, 14217, 1129[[0?]], 29197, 28230, 967. A smaller group reads 1369, 640, [[729?]]. A bottom entry reads “1 Box” followed by an unclear item and 240.

Reading note. The reference reading records figures without correcting the arithmetic. The underlying purchase list still needs better imaging.

Scan 038 10-038

R. B. Potter's corn account, August 1, 1874

August 1, 1874: account with R. B. Potter.

Sixteen bushels of corn at 75 — 12.00.

“Settlement with Gibson”: five bushels of corn at 75 — 3.75.

The rest of the spread contains independent-looking arithmetic. Left-page groups include 16, 75, 80, 11200; 2220 divided by four, 555; 2070, 150, 2220, 1200, 1020 divided by five, 204, 5, 284, 640, 356, 1780 divided by three, 593; 560, 80, 480, 5, 2400, 200, 2600 divided by five, [[514?]]; and 640, [[80?]], 560, 204, 356.

Right-page groups include 1567, 1344, 2911 divided by two, 1455½, 303, 4365, 4365, further unclear figures, 441015; 1059, 303, 756 divided by two, 378; 1567, 1780, 3347 divided by two, 1673½, 388, 13064, 8165, 4879, 499, [[584178?]], 441015; and longer division work beginning 5646)1025808(181 and 5446)971603(17[[unclear]]. Several lower calculations overlap and remain unresolved.

Reading note. “Bushels” expands Bu. The named corn account is separate from the uncategorized calculations; their results have not been corrected.

Scan 039 10-039

Robison accounts: plow repairs, lumber, sawing, and fence posts, 1874

Manuscript page 90: account with [[W. H.?]] Robison.

March 20, 1874: sharpened one plow — 0.25; repaired a plow foot; made a clevis for a doubletree. A credit of 0.95 follows.

May 22, 1874: sharpened one plow — 0.25.

June 13, 1874: “Account in all,” 2.30.

September: repairs to a wagon axle; two nuts; one four-inch bolt; six bolts, half an inch by four inches.

Manuscript page 91: account with [[J. J.?]] Robison.

March 10, 1874: 600 feet, C. F. — 6.50; one day's sawing — 2.50.

March 28, 1874: [[160?]] feet, c. f. — 4.00.

March 1874: 55 fence posts and four “Double” — 5.90. Total written below: 19.00.

Credit to [[balance account?]] — 4.55.

Credit, June 13, 1874 — 10.00.

Separate calculation: 19.00, 4.55, 14.45.

Reading note. These entries describe services and materials. Initials and abbreviations remain uncertain; no kinship is inferred.

Scan 040 10-040

J. J. Gibson's lumber account and a flour credit, 1872–1873

Manuscript page 93: J. J. Gibson's account, with debit and credit columns.

October 23, 1872: 554 feet, c. f. — debit 13.85, credit 10.00.

November 23: 780 feet, c. f. — 17.00; 100 feet, c. f., for lathing — 2.50; 71 feet of scantling — 1.77. A credit of 10.90 follows.

January 7, 1873: 570 feet, c. f. — debit 14.25, credit 12.00.

February 1873: 300 feet, c. f., *[[through Calder?]]* — debit 7.50, credit 7.50.

Visible totals or balance figures include 57.37 / 40.40, 44.90, and 12.47, with further unclear figures.

A note records a credit for one sack of flour from *[[B. S.?]]* Douglas. A large diagonal annotation is not securely readable.

The facing page is filled with arithmetic. The top groups include 1727 / 1800 / 2055 / 863, then 841 / 841 / 888 / 25, then 886 / 1059 / 1300 / 888; and 168000, 127716, 40284, 4, *[[4000284?]]*. Much of the remaining arithmetic overlaps and cannot be reliably separated. An inverted note starts “Account with Ellis” but is incomplete.

Reading note. The source has unresolved figures; this is not a reconciled account. The uncertain Douglas initials are not used to identify a relative.

Scan 041 10-041

A lumber sale to D. A. Sweatt through Henry Davis

A ledger entry headed January 14, 1873 records a sale to D. A. Sweatt on November 26, 1872, through Henry Davis: 200 feet, c. f. — 5.00.

The facing page contains faint notes or names with amounts 20.00, 25.00, and *[[25.00?]]*, partially covered by pen practice. The first name may be *[[Benton?]]*; the others are unresolved.

Calculation groups there read 393, 240, 2358, 1572, 786, 96678; 4840, 20, 96800, 618, 125; 393, 122, 271, *[[366?]]*; and 60, 40, 20, 20, 50, 190.

Below the sale are two columns: 250 / 571; 225 / 759; 84 / 1350; 12 / 2680; 571 / 24; 759 / 5080; 1330 / 1158; *[[4770?]]* / 3922; and faint additional figures.

Reading note. The two dates are distinguished rather than treated as conflicting dates for the same action.

Scan 042 10-042

Dunn and *[[Worley?]]* lumber entries, 1872–1873

The right page is headed January 14, 1873. It records a sale to Dunn and *[[Worley?]]* dated November 24, 1872: 30 feet of strips — 0.75.

March 22, 1873: 175 feet, c. f. — 4.35.

The facing page contains arithmetic. Visible groups include 336 / 1344, 146 / 146, 2016 / 1198; 1344, 336, 49056; a division-like arrangement 5644)49056(8, followed by 45188 and *[[4868?]]*; 1198, 3800, 80; then 1198, 380, 35840, 3594, *[[445540?]]*, 45188, *[[3360?]]*. Other calculations overlap and are not fully recoverable.

Reading note. The March entry may repeat the earlier Tom Dunn account, but the uncertain second name has not been silently standardized.

Scan 043 10-043

Ornamental pen practice and a scantling account

The left page is covered with ornamental handwriting practice over scratch arithmetic. Most words cannot be read confidently; “County of Ellis” is clear. No signature or complete statement is established.

The facing page is dated January 14, 1873: account against *[[Reaves?]]*, 86 feet of scantling — 2.15.

Visible calculation groups include 1021, 180, 841, *[[871?]]*; a division-like arrangement

1560)49000(31½, then 4680, 2200, 1560, 640, 1560; 441, 44, 397 divided by four, 99; 260 divided by four, 65; 300, 31½, 3, 94½, 11½, 1034; and 1086, 65, 1021. Additional figures overlap or run in a different direction and remain unresolved.

Reading note. Scantling is small structural lumber. The account surname needs review; the ornate pen trials are not treated as genealogical evidence.

Scan 044 10-044

Douglas name practice and inside-cover arithmetic

The last notebook leaf contains ornate writing practice, including “Douglas,” “Douglass,” and “Sometime,” repeated in different hands or styles. Other flourished phrases are uncertain. “County of” and a word that appears to read “Plantation” occur among the practice text, but no complete address or property description can be established.

The inside back cover contains worn, partly unreadable calculations and digit practice. Visible figures include 28, 42, *[[160?]]*, 178, *[[1259?]]*, *[[3245?]]*, 134, *[[6930?]]*, *[[3298?]]*, 1145, 1265, and *[[1781?]]*.

Reading note. These are pen trials, not proof of a person’s full name, residence, or ownership. The two surname spellings are preserved.

Scan 045 10-045

“Parody”: a rose offered in friendship, April 1868

The first rose of summer,
fresh, blooming, and beautiful,
sends its sweet fragrance
into the gentle air.

How sweetly it blushes,
like a young woman’s cheek
when she feels emotions
her lips cannot express.

I will not leave you, beautiful rose,
to bloom on your stem.

I will gather you gently,
the day’s sweetest jewel,
while the dewdrop still rests
on your bright leaves,
like a tear on the eyelashes
when a loving heart grieves.

Soon I will give you
 as a token of true friendship
 to someone who will value you
 with the same affection throughout life.
 True hearts never wither,
 even when youth's beauty has gone;
 love remains unchanged
 where friendship first appeared.

April 1868.

Reading note. A modern-language reading of the complete poem. Its presence in the papers alone does not establish authorship.

Scan 046 10-046

"To Emma," of Zephyrus Bower

To Emma, of Zephyrus Bower, by "Moore" the second.

Part One

Wake, my sweet lyre.
 I long for love
 as pure as the desires
 of angels in heaven.
 May the hopes I cherish
 never die
 and cast a dark shadow
 over imagination's first flowering.
 May they live forever,
 flowing like a river,
 a torrent of love.
 Welcome the hour
 when it reaches Emma's garden retreat,
 where your sweet power
 carries me along.
 The Muses all around
 enchant the beautiful place
 with music's sweet sound,
 a heavenly song.
 My happiness is complete
 as, at Emma's feet,
 I softly say,
 and swear to every word,
 that I love her dearly—
 by everything above her—
 and will until time is over:
 my dear Emma Couch.

Part Two

Wake, my sweet lyre.
Affection's longing,
a heavenly fire,
runs through my veins.
Let your sweet sound
float all around,
echoing gently
in melodious music.
For wonderful Emma
will never be mine
unless I can shine
through poetry's power.
For no other reason
will I present myself
as a second "Tom Moore"
at Zephyrus Bower.
But I fondly imagine
that poetry will raise me up,
and perhaps I may succeed
in Emma's eyes.
Then life will be bright,
joyful and light;
and to young love
it will truly be paradise.

Part Three

Wake, my sweet lyre.
You know what I want.
Go now and kindle love
in another young heart.
Then you will prove
that you can awaken love
in a garden retreat or a grove,
wherever you begin.
Let love's sweetest song
prolong your music
as it moves through
that leafy retreat.
Its stirred perfumes
will awaken Emma
to live as the unrivaled
maiden of your garden.

Reading note. "Lyre" is the poet's instrument and a figure for poetry; "bower" is a leafy retreat; "Elysium" means a paradise. The romantic voice is not treated as proof of an actual courtship.

Scan 047 10-047

"Bachelor's Lament," July 1875

Oh, where is the hope of a vine-covered cottage,
the dream that youth so often calls to mind?
It has gone forever; now, gray and grown old,
I have drunk life's bitterest cup to its last drop.
Where is the dear one I have loved devotedly
through life's changing scenes of troubled turmoil,
with the same constant, unchanging feeling,
loved at the beginning and loved to the end?

No answer comes from my silent surroundings.
Silence and gloom are always my companions.
I am as sad as if I had sunk to the ocean's greatest depths,
where the dead of the past lie decaying.
When will this dreadful desolation end,
this suffering that holds my soul down?
Will there be no time of peaceful comfort,
no morning opening again like a rose?

Now I wander alone along life's rough paths.
I may never again greet the friends of my youth.
Many have fallen on faraway roads
and beckon me toward the shore of death.
Beneath that low mound, where the willow weeps,
my heart's only darling sleeps forever.
May the Angel of Death hurry with his harvest
and gather me there to dreamless rest!

Then those breaking bonds will cease forever,
and I will rest sweetly in the grave's calm.
No storms can reach me until the morning of resurrection
calls the dead back to joy or sorrow.
No sign of danger will linger around me,
as it did when I wandered sadly and alone.
A stranger to everything except deep, dreamless peace,
I will rest quietly from the sorrows of my life.

Reading note. The Stygian shore is a classical image of the world of the dead. This modern-language reading follows the revised wording in stanza two. Compare the earlier notebook drafts at 10-021 and 10-026; they are separate versions, not evidence that every faint word is now resolved.

Scan 048 10-048

"To Victoria," concluding stanzas, July 1875

So Inez was to me the impurity in the gold,
the dead shadow of midnight over the soul's hope,

the glowworm's cold light where poisonous vines drip
their deadly dew deep in the dark forest.

But looking back through the shadowy years,
my Ida's sweet smile remains unchanged,
as it was before the tempter entered my paradise
and destroyed my sweet flower, leaving me this.

July 1875.

Reading note. The ending of "To Victoria"; read 10-049 first. These are the poetic speaker's judgments, not a verified account of the women's conduct or identities.

Scan 049 10-049

"To Victoria": welcome to Brushy

Welcome, Victoria, to Brushy's green slopes,
where my bachelor hopes were born and buried.
Here they opened, flourished, and decayed,
like flowers struck by frost in a pleasant May.

But why should I trouble you with my sorrows?
Thousands have felt them, and thousands complain.
May the kind angel watching over your path
protect you from them wherever you go.

The hours have been wonderfully happy since you came to Brushy.
Pleasures that once existed only in name are real now.
Our conversations are sweeter than roses,
and the swiftly passing moments are brighter than gold.

I am not speaking of love: that spring has dried up.
Deception and falsehood have stopped its flow.
Experience has taught me that the daughters of Eve,
even the fairest and brightest, were born to deceive.

Sweet Ida was fickle, yet her image
is carved in my heart and will never leave.
But Inez has stained her young reputation with falsehood,
and a Douglas's curse now rests on her name.

Tell me why an honest person should feel sympathy
for the glittering impurity mixed into gold.
What harmony is there between night and morning,
or between a glowworm's cold light and the sun's gentle ray?

Reading note. Continues at 10-048. The poem expresses bitterness as well as welcome. The speaker's allegations and broad claims about women are preserved as literary content, without endorsement or genealogical inference.

Scan 050 10-050

“On the Banks of Brushy”: remembered childhood landscapes

Beautiful Brushy! Once again I wander beside your winding stream,
as I did in childhood.

Eagerly I dream again the early dreams
that once delighted my innocent younger self.
My memory still wanders fondly over them,
sweet treasures of a past that has gone forever,
doomed to decay in the darkness of forgetting,
where everything pure and bright is quickly heading,
to mingle at last with the earth’s ordinary clay.

Here I first heard the skylark singing
as it rose high above its dew-covered nest.
Here, from a thousand other comical little throats,
I heard the songs swelling each tender breast,
rising to heaven as though, with innocent hearts,
they blessed the great Creator’s name:
he who clothed everything in such beauty
and gave them freedom here,
untouched by humanity’s dark and cunning ways.

Here too I gathered the lovely flowers
that grew abundantly on each green lawn,
adding the charm of their many colors—
beauty that could not be restored once the flowers were gone.
Then I wandered on with aimless steps
to find others sweeter still,
until the coming of evening
turned my wandering feet toward home,
away from many a pleasant, flower-filled retreat.

But before leaving each lovely landscape,
I gathered from many a lonely, mossy valley
the beautiful violets growing so abundantly
in woodland thickets and tangled marshes—

Reading note. Continues at 10-051. This is a complete modern-language reading of the text on this scan page; it does not establish where a particular ancestor spent childhood.

Scan 051 10-051

“On the Banks of Brushy”: flower battles and youthful ambition

I named each flower after one of the world’s famous men,
counted out the designated numbers for each side,
and eagerly began a pretend battle.

When the battle of flowers ended and all but one had died,
my heart thrilled with a boy’s pride in the last victor.

I imagined that, like that flower, I would defeat
 all who stood against me as enemies.
 I would see the last opponent fall
 who dared challenge my right to rule.
 My life would end in victory and peace:
 that was the symbol I saw in the flower.
 I failed to notice how soon it died beside
 those it had defeated in its stormy battle,
 all of them yielding to a greater power.

But as those lovely flowers withered and died
 together in one fragrant heap,
 so those early joys died—joys linked
 to a future in which my sweeping imagination
 grasped at immortality and urged me
 to hold my head high through the coming years
 and climb the long-desired heights of fame,
 whose rugged summit rose in the distant future
 above the crowd's mocking jeers.

Still, those early scenes remain fresh.
 The brighter dreams of childhood
 shine from far away, through the darkness between us.
 Their distance makes them seem twice as sublime
 in beauty, glory, and grandeur as they appeared
 to my young, delighted eyes—
 just as the measured rhythms of passionate verse
 lend dignity to wise writing,
 making it more majestic when clothed in poetry.

Reading note. Continues 10-050. The next manuscript page is displaced in the PDF: continue at 10-060, then 10-061, 10-052, and 10-053.

Scan 052 10-052

Childhood morning, school, and play: "On the Banks of Brushy" sequence

Once again the sun is in the glowing east,
 and the day has arrived, beautiful and bright.
 Released once more from sweet sleep,
 all nature welcomes the great return of light.
 Once again, before my eager, delighted eyes,
 dewdrops sparkle on a thousand flowers,
 from pure crimson to spotless white,
 glowing richly in nature's springtime retreats
 and adding their sweetest perfumes to the returning hours.

The lowing herds wander out to graze
 freely across meadows and hills in wide pastures.
 Their softly tinkling bells ring merrily

on the morning air as they pass.
 In a thousand thickets, songbirds cheerfully
 sing their sweet, contrasting notes to heaven,
 forming a sweeter chorus than any
 we have heard from well-trained choirs,
 as it floats gently heavenward through the soft air.

But school time has come; we must go
 with satchels and baskets, and under the teacher's eye
 study our lessons in a monotonous chant,
 stealing many glances at the bright blue sky.
 We long to escape the confined schoolroom
 for the cool stream or the grove's deep springtime shade,
 or to chase a butterfly across the flowery plain,
 where it has wandered all morning,
 sipping sweetness from the flowers among which it played.

Welcome, wonderful playtime! Free for a while,
 we greet you with wild shouts in the open air,
 as happy as people can be,
 with our spare hour now available for pleasure—

Reading note. Read after 10-061 and before 10-053. The reading follows the authorial revisions in the birdsong stanza.

Scan 053 10-053

Schoolboy friendship threatened by cruelty and slander

Putting aside every thought and worry
 that might get in the way of cheerful pleasure,
 we divide into equal sides and prepare
 for boys' games, paying attention to nothing else.
 With laughter and shouts, we hurry the flying hours along.

How happy that time is! Unburdened by anxious forebodings,
 the bright hours fly by in joy.

Our present hopes are fully satisfied
 and suggest no shadows in life's evening.
 Sadly, those shadows do come over us,
 blighting young friendship at its earliest stage
 and drowning its first, purest, blessed happiness
 beneath the dark, muddy flood of slander,
 whose boiling tide overwhelms everything good.

Why must the schoolboy's flowery path
 be lined with thorns at every step?
 Why must the happy gardens of his young life
 hide a serpent among their flowers?
 Its poisonous fangs, hidden in the many heads

of hatred, malice, scorn, contempt, and pride,
 strike with all their innate venom,
 until the heart's nobler feelings have died
 or joined themselves to Lucifer's baseness.

Reading note. Continues 10-052. The meaning "paying attention to nothing else" is inferred from a grammatically awkward source line.

Scan 054 10-054

"Things I Love," written for Miss Ida

I love all lovely things
 whose beauty *[[arises?]]*
 to captivate the heart:
 from lichens on a mountain summit
 to low valleys clothed in sunlight,
 the high places and the low;
 the hero's proud, grand authority,
 the Senate's stern commands,
 the plowman's small, unnoticed day,
 the humblest people in our land,
 the magnificently great and the lowly *[[word unreadable]]*—
 all have their charm.
 There is splendor in one and beauty in another,
 keeping life's blood warm.

Mutual promises and mutual trust
 are joys that time can never corrode
 or diminish.
 They pass from one sympathetic heart to another
 and make up life's sweeter part,
 whose *[[joys?]]* never disappear.
 Bodies may decay, friends may become distant,
 and beautiful things may vanish.
 Time's silent steps and quiet changes
 may bring death to the fairest.
 But these joys will always remain to comfort us,
 even when everything else is gone,
 and life will shine with rosy light,
 as if dawn lasted forever.

Reading note. Read 10-054, 10-057, then 10-056 for the manuscript's sequence. The poem is dedicated to Miss Ida, whose surname and relationship to the writer remain unestablished.

Scan 055 10-055

"Apostrophe to the Brazos": concluding stanzas, June 1874

Soon we will pass away, leaving
 not a single trace to show what we were.

Like a fragile thread of spider silk blown by the wind,
 we will go, and no one may ever mark
 where we fall. Life's eager, busy people
 will have no time to pause. After we are gone,
 the young and cheerful will laugh around us,
 still led onward in pursuit of life's empty *[[illusions?]]*,
 until they too join us in experiencing the Great Beyond.

Flow on, river; keep flowing. The sea
 will welcome you into its deep, dark depths.
 Your course is set, and in you I can *[[see?]]*
 a likeness of human life. We too cannot escape
 the fate awaiting us: the sorrow or happiness
 of the last hour that must come to everyone.
 There we give up this life's splendor and fame
 in the deep sleep of our final quiet *[[word unreadable]]*,
 until called to join the multitude in that eternal heavenly hall.

June 1874.

Reading note. A modern-language reading of the concluding page. Faded words remain marked; related notebook drafts are at 10-016–10-018. Read 10-059 and 10-058 before this conclusion.

Scan 056 10-056

"Things I Love": friendship and faith, February 1873

I also love the easy flow of friendship,
 the warm glow of sociable feelings,
 the heart's *[[responding?]]* beat;
 happy, sunlit hours of delight,
 spent openly and *[[freely?]]* with friends,
 and the beloved retreat beside the fire;
 the blushing cheek and sparkling eye
 that speak of sincere souls,
 of hopes and high ambitions
 carried in young hearts;
 the mysterious power of twilight
 when the stars begin to shine;
 and the gentle rest of day's end—
 these are joys I count as mine.

But more than the grandest things
 the earth can offer or genius can create,
 I value those who will inherit heaven:
 those who bow beneath God's hand,
 smile through their tears, and kiss the rod
 before its blow has even fallen.
 Still lonely pilgrims and strangers here
 in a world of conflict,

they live purely and keep clear consciences,
 their claim to *[[eternal life?]]*.
 With a living faith that conquers death,
 a lofty and holy trust,
 they calmly await the final *[[command?]]*:
 “You shall return to dust.”

February 1873.

Reading note. The ending of “Things I Love,” beginning at 10-054 and continuing at 10-057. A modern reading of the complete page, with uncertainty retained in the faded words.

Scan 057 10-057

“Things I Love”: beauty in ordinary places

Anyone who will not pause to notice the happiness
 arising from delightful *[[imagined?]]* scenes
 is dead to everything dear.
 The seasons return for him in vain;
 the poles may freeze and the tropics *[[burn?]]*,
 but the year is all the same to him.
 Flowers scattered across the green prairies
 may appeal silently,
 yet neither a grove full of song nor a woodland scene
 can make him feel anything.
 I can still notice every delight
 arising on a plain or a leafy branch,
 and sincerely love them,
 both the gentle and the cheerful.

However humble the scene,
 I am sure a thrill of delight *[[has been?]]*
 there for a while.
 So I will gather the unnamed sweetness
 from every lonely, obscure *[[retreat?]]*,
 half hidden from the daylight.
 Meadows and mountain summits still
[[offer?]] their varied beauties.
 Summer’s flowers and winter’s snow
 still give me joys made enduring.
 I eagerly embrace each one
 with a grateful, beating heart.
 I love them all, the great and the *[[small?]]*,
 for the delight they give.

Reading note. The middle page of “Things I Love.” The meaning “made enduring” interprets the unusual word “annealed”; the archival transcript preserves that wording.

Scan 058 10-058

“Apostrophe to the Brazos”: companionship and remembrance

We surrender to the gentle charm
that quickly makes the day’s worries *[[depart?]]*,
with all their burden of human hatred and deceit,
and frees the nobler part of ourselves,
where the heart’s sweeter feelings reign.

How delightful it is then to wander in the evening
along that rocky mountain’s wooded crest,
passing pleasant, sunny hours
in friendly conversation, whose influence
I still feel with all the charms of life I know.
Of *[[words unreadable]]* life, shared with one dear friend,
as *[[words unreadable]]* on that old live-oak bough,
mutual respect and confidence mingled,
while youth and hope added their shared charm.

Your eternal hills spread around us,
garlanded with unfading greenery.
In their leafy retreats the mockingbirds’ gentle *[[songs?]]*
awakened thoughts of what might have been.
Below lay your beautiful, winding valleys,
cultivated by the sturdy plowman.
The simple cottage humbly completed the scene:
a poor man’s home and his beloved household,
the dearest bond in every patriot’s country.

These scenes and thoughts awaken us, and we forget
the Indigenous person’s grave and the white person’s tomb.
They lived, loved, hoped, and worked; yet
death came and broke all the cherished bonds
that tied them to life. And *[[words unreadable]]*
idle and indifferent above their honored remains,
and violate the tombs that affection’s tears
raised to honor and protect the worthy dead
against time’s destruction and the decay of forgetting.

Reading note. The middle page of “Apostrophe to the Brazos.” Read 10-059, 10-058, then 10-055. The modern version keeps genuine gaps rather than inventing a complete scene.

Scan 059 10-059

“Apostrophe to the Brazos”

Sweet Brazos! Your murmuring waters still wash
your pebbled bank beneath that mountain,
whose summit is crowned by an ancient Indigenous grave—
the grave of one who was his nation’s pride and strength.

Some hundred years have wearily passed
 since he was placed in the warrior's tomb.
 What change there has been! What destructive force
 has condemned the Indigenous man to an early end,
 sweeping him from the earth to make room for the white man.

Yet you flow on as in earlier days,
 with the same sounds in your rocky bed.
 Rugged cliffs still crown your winding shore;
 perhaps an ancient tree still lifts its head.
 Except for these, all *[[other?]]* scenes are gone:
 the proud, strong warrior and his dark-skinned bride,
 the powerful chief and his trusted horse are dead;
 the dwelling is gone, with all the Indigenous man's pride,
 swept away by the passing years, *[[words unreadable]]* from their changing tide.

Though they are gone, hearts just as loving, brave,
 and deeply faithful still beat beside your stream,
 as those your distant earliest ages gave
 to the world. They dream just as *[[vainly?]]*
 of love and happiness, fondly imagining
 that in later years they will grasp the wand
 of human happiness, whose rich, deceptive glow,
 seen far away, leads them fruitlessly onward
 until youth, health, strength, hope, and life are gone.

Even so, let us seize the hour
 that shines with love and hope's deceptive smile.
 Let us welcome its presence and its cheerful power
 around us, even for so short a time—

Reading note. A complete modern-language reading of this page, continuing at 10-058. The poem's account of Indigenous people is the speaker's historical viewpoint, not a verified description of a nation's disappearance or a specific burial site.

Scan 060 10-060

"On the Banks of Brushy": twilight and remembered youth

The early scenes I first knew still linger
 on the pages of the shadowy past.
 As memory turns those pages, they appear
 in pure, unstained colors that will remain
 when age has bound me,
 when earthly pleasures dim and fade,
 and the last sands of life run quickly out,
 soon to mingle with the earth's ordinary clay,
 where everything must eventually decay.

How beautiful the sky looked in twilight
 when the glaring day was over,
 and the glorious sun's last lingering rays
 streaked the deep heavenly blue with amber.
 To my boyish eyes that splendid view
 seemed like the gates of heaven,
 through which we might leap from the horizon
 to taste immortal happiness above the sky
 with the pure spirits who never die.

As night's colors deepened
 on the far western horizon,
 the stars emerged with their lovely light
 and gazed down like blessed spirits,
 watching the earth sink calmly to rest
 from the work and cares of days spent here,
 from the fierce pursuits eagerly followed
 by people seeking high positions of power
 so they can dispense curses upon humanity by the hour.

How gently, as the quiet night advances,
 its mild influence falls on humanity's stormy soul!
 It erases the day's wounds and brings *[[unasked?]]*
 that gift of heaven, whose high goal—

Reading note. A displaced continuation of “On the Banks of Brushy,” between 10-051 and 10-061. “Wounds” interprets the source’s “stripes”; the uncertain following word remains marked.

Scan 061 10-061

“On the Banks of Brushy”: childhood sleep and mortality

—is fixed where time's waves can never roll,
 nor reach with their corrosion and decay:
 the immortal spirit's distant magnetic pole,
 around which it travels eternally
 in the boundless light of an endless day.

At last, when everything outside was calm and still,
 I would seek childhood dreams in deep sleep,
 softly lulled by the solitary whip-poor-will
 singing sweetly in the gentle night light.
 To my young imagination, it seemed
 a lovely creature endowed with unnamed, pure charms
 and unequaled beauty shining in the starlight,
 bright enough to stir a poet's imagination
 while asleep in the arms of Morpheus.

How quiet childhood's sleep is, how free
 from the stormy dreams of adult, feverish sleep!

No restless turmoil, no collapse of lofty, empty ambitions,
 no dying hopes to wake and weep over.
 Everything is peace and gentle rest, keeping
 a starry watch over the young, tender body,
 resting so deeply in sweet unconsciousness
 that it seems a pity it must ever wake
 to take its place again on the rough road to earthly fame.

Oh, it would be far better, in our earliest days,
 before we learn sin's tormenting ways,
 for death to extinguish life's beloved bright light
 and for us to sink into the tomb, though it is cold within.
 Cold as its vault may be, it is there,
 through that bleak doorway, that the chain
 of icy bondage is broken; triumphing
 in the struggle with death, we return to heaven,
 resting in victory's happiness and the end of pain.

Reading note. Read between 10-060 and 10-052. Morpheus represents sleep. The last stanza's modern wording gives the apparent religious sense of a grammatically difficult passage; consult the archival text for its exact construction.

Scan 062 10-062

Poetry notebook: contents list

Contents of a poetry notebook, with its original page references:

To Miss M. L. G. — 5

To Miss M. L. G. — 9

Idle Hours — 39 (an earlier number is crossed out)

[[Unreadable title]] — 12

[[Sonnet?]] — *[[remainder unreadable]]*

Definition of Love — 62

[[Faint unreadable entry]]

To the Y. L. of the L. S. — 18

Sonnet — 14

Idle Hours — 37

"Home" — 14

To Miss M. A. A. — 54

To W. H. *[[Bunn?]]*, Esquire — 16

To Miss M. L. G. — 40

Idle Hours — 31

A Visit to Siloam — 58

To Miss M. A. A. — 22

To the Same — 24

To Miss Mat. A. — 63

Idle Hours — 39–52

On the Death of B. D. Andrews — 44

Varying Moments — 48

For an Album — 21

For an Album — 20

The notebook uses printed Confederate Army forms as writing paper. The printed fields concern physical description, birthplace, and remarks; they have not been filled in as military records on this page.

Reading note. Initials are retained without guessing full names. The list's numbers refer to its own notebook, not this edition's scan-page numbers.

Scan 063 10-063

"Convivial Journal," 1866–1867

"Convivial Journal," January 1866.

January 1: E. M. Sears is named, followed by a long list largely in initials. Readable groups include H. G. O., A. L. O., J. N. O., R. E. O., G. O., J. W. O., R. N. A., D. G., J. W. R., M. E., G. R., A. C., T. L., R. C., L. G., C. C. B., two M. B. groups, M. A. A., M. A., E. C., M. L. G., E. C., A. S., A. D., and S. G. There are uncertain groups and small raised numbers throughout; see the archival reading for their arrangement.

January [[9?]]: Wm A. and T. L. begin another long list of initials, including [[H. Met.?]], A. L. O., R. E. O., J. N. O., G. O., J. W. O., J. & W. O., R. E. O., E. E. A., D. G., J. G., S. B., J. W. R., J. D., B. B., B. S., G. C., J. G., J. T., L. P., W. T., L. G., M. A. A., M. A., G. M., E. P., M. C., L. C., W. H., and M. L. G. Some material remains unclear.

January 11: A further list of initials, beginning J. M. [[B. L.??]] and J. W. R. The exact separation of several initials is uncertain; see the archival reading. A short note to the right is largely unreadable.

January 16 and 20: Entries contain partial names and initials, including Geo, Wm, Ed, [[Joseph?]], [[Tom?]], and [[Nipp?]] & Neck. Most of the surrounding wording cannot be reliably recovered.

June 1866: Henry Andrews, followed by unreadable names or words.

January 1, 1867: At J. H. A. McKnight's, with R. L. O. H., W. T. M. B., [[unreadable]], [[Sandy?]], Wm C., Em. L., Em. M. A. A. present. Some boundaries between the initials remain uncertain.

Reading note. This is a guided reading of a difficult list, not a complete identification of the people. Small raised numbers have an unexplained function; the archival version attempts to preserve them. The reused form is not evidence that these were military gatherings.

Scan 064 10-064

Brief journal entries, August and September 1866

August [[30?]], 1866: An incomplete entry mentions "Cousin Mollie" being present and threatening to write to the diarist. A following phrase may say "to save my life," but the remainder is too faint to reconstruct reliably.

September 20: A small wedding at [[Greenwood?]] went very well, considering the bad weather. The first norther of the season had arrived, making things a little cool as well as comfortable.

Reading note. The August entry is explicitly partial. A "norther" is a cold northerly wind. The place name and the people getting married are not securely identified.

Scan 065 10-065

To Miss M. L. G.: courtship after peace returns

Now gentle peace has returned,
and every girl wants a man,
while every man is in a whirl,
looking for a girl
to share the rest of his life
as his companion, partner, and wife.
Everything is bustle and confusion
around the marriage bower. Any mention
of tying two people together
in lifelong bonds
will not suit a young fellow
unless he is a daring one.

But everyone has a special preference
beyond his ordinary feelings.
I sincerely think “Elm Grove”
will fulfill the ideal I favor.
I do intend to win
the prize shining there,
though I will doubtless face opposition
in my efforts.
I know of only four
who oppose my plans,
but they may give me serious trouble,
for they are gentlemanly and clever.
I will describe them one by one;
please forgive any digression
or irregularity in the meter,
for that is an allowable poetic offense.

Reading note. The first page of a playful courtship poem; continues at 10-066. The recipient's initials are preserved, and the rivals' labels are not expanded into guessed identities.

Scan 066 10-066

To Miss M. L. G.: the rivals “Elysian,” “Bloomdale,” and “Shiloh”

“Elysian’s” claims are longstanding and strong,
and a splendid home awaits you there,
which you may soon enjoy
as an inherited marriage portion.
But I honestly believe
the owner will never suit:
he will certainly deceive
others, so why not you?
I admit his claims are old enough

to win the prize if they are faithful enough.
 But I doubt their constancy,
 having heard the idle gossip
 circulating all around.

“Bloomdale” has found his speaking voice,
 and very often I hear it squeak.
 I do not fear his subtle wit,
 but once he takes hold he will never release
 the object he seeks
 until the prize is securely caught.
 Yet there are so many “ifs” and “ands,”
 and “I will manage it if I can,”
 followed by “When and where should I show my love?
 I do not know how to prove it
 so as to win the prize of Elm Grove.”

From “Shiloh” there sometimes loudly comes
 a brave and handsome boy,
 who strikes my heart speechless with fear
 and threatens to spoil my happiness forever.
 Oh, may time’s destructive arrows fall—

Reading note. Continues 10-065 and runs on into 10-067. This is teasing rivalry in verse; the men’s identities and the truth of the speaker’s accusations are not established.

Scan 067 10-067

To Miss M. L. G.: mock curses and a fourth rival

—upon his glowing face,
 in thick, swift, terrible showers!
 May they destroy every lovely trace
 of his now-radiant features
 and leave him limping, lame, sick, and unsound,
 with all the troubles that quickly prepare
 a failing body for the grave,
 because he leaves home to spoil the happiness
 of other, better boys,
 who claim the right to choose first
 among the sweet-voiced young women
 living nearby in the country,
 all so very dear to me.
 I can love every one of them individually,
 but most of all the prize of “Elm Grove.”

“Seclusion” will also make his claim
 from his secluded retreat.
 They will get—[[*the meaning of “howies” is unclear*]]—only in name,
 so I do not care about their powers.

Perhaps [[“howies,” meaning unclear]], since he condemns everyone
 who does not meet his ideal;
 he may let his curses fall
 on this glorious rival.
 Let them come! If his harsh opinion
 hurts your feelings,
 “I will peel his muddy head,”
 as an Irishman might peel an onion.

Yes, come quickly to me, dearest girl,
 and I will protect you—

Reading note. Continues 10-066 and ends at 10-068. The source uses comic exaggeration, unusual words, and an ethnic stereotype; unclear wording is marked rather than softened into an invented meaning.

Scan 068 10-068

To Miss M. L. G., May 1, 1866; four epigrams

—until this body is laid in the grave
 and I cease to live.
 Your image will always remain
 enshrined in my heart.
 Will you not come and stay
 there forever with it?

My misery on earth is complete,
 living alone as I do.
 My life is a kind of death
 that gives me no pleasure.
 I know I will soon die
 because no one loves me.
 I cannot say why that is.
 Can you, fair girl of “Elm Grove”?

I loved you from the beginning and love you even more now;
 I will always love you.
 You can see that from my letter.
 Can you love a “Verdant Hill”?

May 1, 1866.

Four epigrams:

If you want a new wrinkle
 set deeply in your brow,
 go and notice the Rip Van Winkle-like old-fashioned habits
 in Liberty’s social etiquette.

A prayer meeting is “the chief concern,”
 as every sinner knows:

there he can quietly discover
how he stands with Uncle *[[Gid?]]*.

If you want information
from anyone native to Liberty,
do not go to the composition examination:
[[Ben?]] will tell you the compositions are original.

People often go to a party or ball
to find enjoyment,
but there you will find that everyone
goes to a funeral for entertainment.

Reading note. The courtship poem ends here. Its last question and the separate epigrams use wordplay and satire; identities behind “Verdant Hill” and the tentative names remain unresolved.

Scan 069 10-069

To Miss M. L. G.: a reply about the anonymous verses

It is no use trying so hard,
looking around so furtively,
and studying every boy who appears
as though he were the one who wrote
you these scattered verses,
tossed off casually in rustic rhythms.
They made such sudden references
to “Elysian,” “Bloomdale,” “Shiloh,” and “Seclusion,”
and told some very unflattering stories about them,
no doubt making them feel less like important “big fish.”

“Elysian” surely calls it an outrage
against a gentleman of his age,
and loudly rages
at a poor, unknown fellow creature.

“Bloomdale” will doubtless make a show,
raise his brows and feel more important,
simply because I decided
to mention him briefly.

“Shiloh” will surely never know
who has caused him so much trouble.
But if the three get together,
lift their heads and ruffle their feathers,
and strut around as important as Aristotle,
with a big black bottle along,
and happen to see this poor mortal—
what, oh what, would become of me?

The manuscript says: continued on page 53.

Reading note. A playful follow-up to the courtship poem at 10-065–10-068. The family reading interprets the unusual “whales” as a joke about importance; the reference transcript preserves the word. Read the continuation at 10-093–10-096.

Scan 070 10-070

“Social Parties—What Are They?”: a critical account of local gatherings

Social Parties—What Are They?

In my humble opinion, the social parties held by younger people in this area, both those born here and those who have settled here, are among the most ridiculous amusements intelligent people could practice.

Imagine thirty or forty young people, aged eighteen to thirty, gathering at a place chosen for the occasion. After they have sat about idly for a while, looking embarrassed, very modest, and afraid of breaking the rules of etiquette, someone ventures to suggest a “play,” or party game. The young men eagerly choose partners, and before long they are walking around the room in pairs to “Old Sister Phebe,” “My Pretty Little Love,” or another popular song, sung in enchanting fashion by one or two singers.

No couple ever carries on a conversation worth the name. Those who are not singing remain completely silent or laugh uncontrollably at someone’s real or imagined mistakes. When they tire of a game, everyone looks for a seat, a drink of water, or something else to do.

The girls gather on one side of the room and apparently enjoy lively, interesting conversation, judging by the many smiling faces and little giggles that may from time—

Reading note. Continues at 10-071. The amused but disapproving tone belongs to the writer. This text records one person’s view of local social customs.

Scan 071 10-071

“Social Parties”: Ellis County, Texas, May 1866

—to time be seen and heard. Poor things, how they seem to enjoy themselves when they are alone! But let a venturesome young man enter their circle and silence immediately follows, generally making him feel that he may have been the subject of their previous amusement.

The evening passes in this way, varied by all the silly singing games the participants know, until everyone becomes tired and agrees to leave. Each young man escorts his sweetheart home if he has one, while those without sweethearts go home alone *[[qualifying phrase unreadable]]*.

Such is society in Ellis County, Texas, in May 1866. Such is the way the young people behave toward one another. I cannot determine what the proper outcome of all this may be, but I hope it will lead to something more refined and sensible, and to a higher level of sociability than is presently *[[available?]]*.

Something better should be adopted. When pressed, everyone admits feeling ashamed of taking part in such silly amusements. Why not abandon them at once and adopt something we need not be ashamed of? Common sense could suggest many convenient amusements that would be *[[both worthwhile and enjoyable?]]*.

Reading note. The conclusion of 10-070. Ellis County, Texas, and May 1866 are given explicitly in the manuscript. The concluding suggested wording remains uncertain where the scan is faded.

Scan 072 10-072

A Fourth of July school exhibition near Red Oak in 1866

July 4, 1866. I spent the day at the school examination and exhibition at Mrs. *[[Ray's?]]* school, a mile and a half west of the Red Oak post office.

It was a brilliant affair for Texas at this stage of its intellectual development, surpassing anything of its kind held in this part of the country so far. Nothing spoken or performed on stage was original, however; it all came from the mind of some genius elsewhere.

The passing spectacle ended at eleven at night. Judging by appearances, I suppose everyone went home satisfied, and some were doubtless delighted. But I suppose we have no right to speculate about the secrets of all those fluttering hearts that left the grounds. Perhaps not everything that could be told would be pleasant to hear.

As people say, the “skirmish line” was established, and at least one romantic or marital affair was fully accomplished at this occasion of wit and *[[merriment?]]*. May it eventually leave everyone satisfied, happy, and content to go their way rejoicing—if not because their hopes have been fulfilled, then at least because they hope for a better day when they can call the *[[beloved?]]* *[[unreadable]]* their own, if only temporarily.

Sunshine and shadow are strangely mixed in this *[[earthly?]]* world. Those happy today may be *[[sad?]]* tomorrow, and those sad today may be happy tomorrow. It is doubtless *[[more pleasant?]]* to watch these changes than to *[[experience?]]* them. We will wait a while and *[[ending unreadable]]*.

Reading note. An unsigned eyewitness-style entry. The surname and several faded passages need further checking. No couple is named in the romantic allusion.

Scan 073 10-073

Sixteen years in Ellis County and the difficulties of farming

Living in this part of Texas—Ellis County—for sixteen years has certainly not made me fall in love with it. It may be the easiest place to “get along,” yet my experience of ordinary farming here forces me to conclude that it is a hard place to make a living.

The generally mild climate and the *[[slowness?]]* of summer have drained the inhabitants’ energy so much that they fail to plan properly for their financial interests. Proper grain storage is not provided, and crops are often substantially damaged for that reason alone.

We have too little machinery of every kind. There are not even half enough mills in the country. Consequently, we have collusion instead of competition, and excessive milling charges harm the farmers. Yet we farmers must submit to *[[unreadable]]* that we cannot remedy. *[[Part of the argument is unreadable.]]* I cite millers *[[unreadable]]* the community. Other professions act similarly as far as they can.

Self-interest is the governing principle here, *[[to?]]* the exclusion of everything else. *[[Some words are unreadable.]]* Places where competition gives farmers a chance to receive the full value of their crops each year *[[would?]]* surely be more desirable than *[[ending partly unreadable]]*.

Reading note. A valuable migration clue, but the speaker is not identified here. Do not use the sixteen-year statement to assign a firm arrival date or a named ancestor without additional evidence.

Scan 074 10-074

Home and the ties of childhood

Home

The word “home” carries many pleasant associations. It brings the main features of our early days together in a single picture. Our first memories, companions, and relationships all spring to mind at its mention.

We remember the innocent games that filled our childhood, when we played happily among sunshine and flowers, breathing nature’s free air and spirit. We were as carefree as the brightly feathered birds singing praise in every tree, and as free from the world’s follies and vices, never imagining the troubles of later years.

We remember our early friendships with companions as happy as ourselves. Those days can never return, but they remain in memory as one of the brightest periods of our lives, to which we can always turn with pleasure. We remember our first relationships with parents, brothers, and sisters: affectionate ties formed in childhood and never forgotten, however far time and distance take us from their beginnings.

All these memories arise when home is mentioned. As we contemplate them across the years, they acquire a sacred purity that no other scenes or associations can have. They are holy because they belong to the past, and sacred because they are pure, untouched by corrupt relationships. They are the tender ties of early love, enjoyed and returned by everyone—the sacred links that bind the family—

Reading note. Continues at 10-075. The essay idealizes home and childhood; its descriptions do not establish specific biographical events.

Scan 075 10-075

The conclusion of Home and a sonnet on vanished hopes

—together in lasting union.

These associations will always influence us, whatever course our lives take. If we become wild and dissipated, they will restrain us and point toward a nobler life. If we are gentle and refined, they will encourage us to continue doing good, improving our feelings and character. They inspire kindness and contentment in our hearts, a lasting source of happiness that life’s cares cannot destroy.

Written at a young lady’s request.

Seclusion, September 20, 1866.

Sonnet, or Blent Flowers

Farewell, bright hopes that hovered so fondly
 around the light dreams of my early days,
 when, with open feelings and unhidden affection,
 I faced the cheerful world at its brightest.
 Those blissful visions of joy
 have faded before adversity’s cold gaze.
 Nothing remains but those dreams of life’s paradise,
 dimly seen through memory’s dark haze.
 Yet they will linger on those distant pages,
 and sometimes be read when a sunbeam falls there,

and fondly remembered as one of those happy times
 that childhood and youth deceptively offer.
 They will not return at later stages of life,
 although we hope for them through philosophy's airy ways.

Seclusion, July 1866.

Reading note. The prose and poem are separate works. The sonnet is modernized for meaning, including an awkward revised line and unusual final adjective; consult the reference transcript for exact readings.

Scan 076 10-076

To W H B on lasting friendship

To W. H. B.

Though we met only recently,
 I can never forget the few bright, glowing scenes
 we have shared,
 as long as I know what pleasure means.
 I would give those sweet moments,
 which brought such happiness,
 a passing thought
 in these casual, scattered rhymes.

I dedicate my verse to friendship,
 which blooms brightly in the darkest hours.
 Though the verse may be rough and crude,
 a nobler purpose will guide it.

May our newly begun friendship
 stand the test of future years.
 May the bonds that pleasure gladly bears
 be woven firmly around our hearts.

True friendship is like a gnarled oak,
 firmly rooted in rock:
 it feels lightning's deadliest stroke
 and withstands the fiercest storm.
 But when the moaning storms have passed
 and evening comes peacefully,
 it raises its green head again
 toward the vault of heaven.

May we withstand the lightning bolt
 of dark and dreadful malice—

Reading note. Continues at 10-077. The recipient's full name has not been established from the initials.

Scan 077 10-077

George Douglas on friendship and a later farewell verse

—may we remain firmly rooted
while storms of slander burst overhead.
When life's storms have passed
and spent their fury,
friendship will finally point our way
toward the higher courts of heaven.

So I offer true friendship
words that can never be lost.
You will value them highly
while you remain faithful to honor.
If you are ever abandoned
by love's fair but false circle,
old feelings will awaken
when you read what I have written here.

Geo. Douglas
Seclusion, November 18, 1866.

A separate farewell verse

Farewell, for now my eyes grow dim,
and I must leave this blessed home.
Wherever I go, my thoughts will always
alight on dear *[[Matty?]]* Farm.
For in this secluded spot
peaceful hours have passed.
Peace to the *[[hearts?]]* whose happy lot
is to share life here with you.

June 27, 1869. *[[L?]]*

Reading note. The farewell is a separate entry, with uncertain farm name and initial. Its incomplete third line is smoothed for sense in this reading; the reference transcript preserves the wording.

Scan 078 10-078

To the Y L of the L S or the gnawing of a bone

To the Y. L. of the L. S., or Gnawing a Bone

Gentle girls, polite and fair,
since I am alone tonight,
I will try to produce some rhymes
about a tough and crusty bone.

I hear you have a bone to gnaw,
harder than any ever known.

Nobody has seen its like:
it is such a very strange bone.

Every Monday morning, I understand,
you must confess all your faults,
then grip it firmly with both hands
and start gnawing this bone.

Tuesday comes bright and fair,
but it shows no sign of softening.
You spend every busy moment
gnawing away at this bone.

You continue until Saturday,
knowing this tiresome task all week,
but have not gnawed away
even one particle of the hard bone.

Then the pure, bright Sabbath comes,
its glories spread across the earth—

Reading note. Continues at 10-079–10-080. The initials and the target of the joke are not identified.

Scan 079 10-079

The strange bone and a joke about army food

—but you must take a double bite
of this never-ending bone.

I too have been biting something very tough,
unlike anything I have known.
It is neither smooth nor very rough.
Perhaps it is your bone?

When I was in the army,
I ate whatever was thrown to me,
knowing it could not hurt me,
even if it was a dry bone.

But I am less sure about this one,
for it makes my teeth ache, I admit.
I do not enjoy the bliss
of gnawing on this bone.

It is unlike anything I have tried
or anything I have known.
I will search the whole wide world
to find a name for this bone.

It is neither duck, goose, nor chicken,
nor a fattened hog,

but something very hard and slick,
so I am sure it is a bone.

It is not sheep, deer, or horse,
nor anything grown in modern times.
So naturally I think—

Reading note. The humorous comparison continues at 10-080.

Scan 080 10-080

The bone joke concluded and an album blessing
—it must be a bone from Balaam’s donkey.

Now you have my guess,
though I may suffer for it.
Let us put together a costume
to dress our poor bone.

I think it should get what it deserves
in this cold wintry weather:
I propose an overcoat
of genuine tar and feathers.

Seclusion, December 8, 1866.

For an Album

To grace your album’s untouched page,
I bring from the depths of my soul
a pure thought in which love comes first:
an unrestrained offering of devotion.
On the shrine of your friendship I place
a heartfelt wish for blessings from above:
may the brightest suns shine for you,
with no cloud darkening your sky.
May flowers of every brilliant color
bloom along your path,
continually shedding their sweet perfume
from countless heavenly fields.
May love, health, and happiness
be yours wherever you go.
May you be spared loneliness
and the *[[word obscured]]* flowing cup of sorrow.

February 12, 1867. Geo.

Reading note. Two separate poems. The first ends with a hostile joke; the second offers friendship and good wishes. No recipient is named in the album verse.

Scan 081 10-081

An album poem on remembrance in sorrow

For an Album

I have not mastered the task
of adorning an album's untouched page
with thoughts and words suitable
for both youth and mature adulthood.

But since I must appear
among the others on friendship's record,
I hope I will not be valued more highly
merely for having a deeper soul.

I do not ask affection
to remember me when everything is bright.
That is too great a claim for me
to seek lightly and cheerfully.

But when you are given
fierce anguish and a bitter drink,
and friends whose health you have toasted
are roughly driven from your heart,

then remember one who loves
[[next line partly unreadable]],
one who wanders carelessly through life
and breathes no sigh for others' sorrows.

January 1867.

Reading note. The final stanza may contain irony or difficult wording. Its apparent contradiction is preserved rather than rewritten as an uncomplicated promise of sympathy.

Scan 082 10-082

To Miss M A A or fair Mary

To Miss M. A. A.

When heaven's blue arch bends gracefully above me,
glowing with love's azure color,
my mind rises calmly with sweet thoughts
and turns along that bright arch to you, fair Mary.

As a magnetized needle
points steadily and faithfully to the pole,
the deepest affectionate feelings in my heart
are drawn like a magnet to you, fair Mary.

When I recline on the green grassy banks
of fair Red Oak, listening to its flowing water,

with lovely shades intertwining above it,
my affectionate memory turns to you, fair Mary.

The voices of water and birds in those leafy bowers
enchant and draw my restless spirit.
Yet as I listen to their wild chorus,
my delighted heart turns to you, fair Mary.

Like a sunflower extending its face
in early morning, before the bright dew falls away,
to meet the bold gaze of its rising sun,
I open my heart to you, fair Mary.

I stand joyfully in the morning of life,
with bright, pleasant prospects before me.
Hope's cheerful charm expands my heart,
but all those hopes finally point to you, fair Mary.

Reading note. Continues at 10-083–10-084. The poem names Mary but does not supply her full identity or establish that she reciprocated the writer's feelings.

Scan 083 10-083

The plea for Mary's support

How fondly my heart's tendrils entwine
around what is lovely and true in the future.
As a vine leans trustingly on a tree,
my affections lean on you, fair Mary.

But can I claim the lasting support
that a tree gives its vine through the years,
and secure protection from a cynic's cruel mockery?
May I ever hope for this from you, fair Mary?

While autumn's soft wind fans my cheek
and the forests take on their bright, somber color,
while I gaze delightedly at nature's beauty,
my thoughts turn eagerly to you, fair Mary.

When brightly feathered birds swell their harmonies
in soft, thrilling notes, scattered and few,
my heart's pure feelings rise deeply
for nature's wild music and you, fair Mary.

When twilight spreads its dusky mantle over earth,
and we gaze peacefully into the deep blue sky,
my thoughts often climb that starry vault,
and imagination weaves bright garlands for you.

She modestly wreathes the heart's treasures
with the soul's brightly colored gems,

breathing affection over everything,
and smilingly waves the garland to you, fair Mary.

My soul beholds that spirit's bright beam;
imagination paints still brighter joys upon it—

Reading note. Continues at 10-084. The family reading smooths unusual syntax while preserving the uncertainty of the speaker's hopes.

Scan 084 10-084

George Douglas's verses to Mary and To the Same

—its delightful beauties unfold sweetly,
yielding their brightness to you, fair Mary.

While its halo beams beautifully
with a soft, lovely light,
my soul is entranced by these gentle visions,
yet breathes devotion to you, fair Mary.

I now lay friendship's first bright offering
upon your shrine: a fitting gift of faith.
These few simple lines are my soul's own writing,
from the depths of my heart to you, fair Mary.

Geo. Douglas
Seclusion, October 15, 1866.

To the Same

Bright dawn streams across the eastern sky,
waking sleeping nature from its dreamlike rest.
Through the forests rises a cheerful chorus,
the sweetest morning reveille *[[source's phrase about the singers is unclear in meaning]]*.
I spring from my bed; my bright visions
mingle with nature's living reality.
The delights of last night's dreams fade,
but a deeper delight awaits me in you, fair Mary.

The sun springs gloriously from his bed
and rides triumphantly up the bright east,
cheerfully scattering his rays across the wide earth,
which bows beneath his gaze like the loveliest bride.
And nature's music, the hymn she sings—

Reading note. The dated, signed poem ends before "To the Same." The new poem continues at 10-085 and has its own date notation there.

Scan 085 10-085

Birdsong and a heavenly offering to Mary

—in devoted, faithful adoration.

As I hear its wild melody ring,
affection points me toward you, fair Mary.

In a distant bower I hear a ring dove cooing
as it keeps close watch
over the mate it courted in its early days,
who sleeps dreamily on a neighboring branch.
I imagine it has never known the heart's deep restlessness
that troubles us when we love someone lovely and true,
or the wandering hopes of pursuing love
that I have felt for you, fair Mary.

Now a lark springs from its dewy nest
and soars high above the green plain,
singing nature's wild music sweetly
in its Maker's ear amid the blue heavens.
I send my soul along its invisible path,
clothed in lovely heavenly colors.
My spirit rings with the "music of the spheres,"
mixing their sweetness for you, fair Mary.

November 186[[*last digit lost at the edge*]].

Angels descend from heaven's high gates,
carrying bright golden harps.
Rising on faith's wings to meet that shining host,
my spirit crosses the blue sky.
Ten thousand voices, blending harmoniously,
gave me a beautiful, true offering
of radiant love surpassing everything earthly,
and told me to carry it to you, fair Mary.

January 27, 1867.

Reading note. The final stanza has a separate date from the preceding stanzas. Heavenly scenes are poetic imagery, not descriptions of documented events.

Scan 086 10-086

Dutch Campmeeting in September 1866

Dutch Camp Meeting, 1866

In September 1866
I went to the camp meeting.
As well as I can remember,
I received a very cordial welcome.
The first social pleasure I experienced

was a gentle sprinkling,
 which gave me a preview
 and a hint of what was coming.
 There was a shower of rain and heaps of mud,
 and plenty of mud-spattered dresses.
 I caught many a sly glimpse
 of slender ankles, ten or twenty of them.
 The camp accommodations were poor.
 The young women did not enjoy
 sitting on the floor
 on straw instead of grass.
 They would have preferred soft, green,
 dew-sparkling grass beneath a willow,
 each with a handsome young man,
[[an awkward line about two people weaving flowers into garlands]].
 But here the situation was different:
 a preacher restrained the easy conversation
 between gentlemen and young ladies,
 which they would all gladly have enjoyed.
 After a while they grew bolder,
 and some went into the passage.
 What do you think they did there?
 They all mixed together
 in a crowded huddle—

Reading note. Continues at 10-087–10-090. This is comic and sometimes insulting social verse, not a neutral account.

Scan 087 10-087

Camp meeting conversation and flirtation

—untroubled by the weather,
 the falling rain or splashing puddles.
 Now and then, I suspect,
 a softer word slipped into the conversation,
 heard by the intended person,
 who did not think it sinful.
 But I do not know this;
 I am only guessing.
[[The next two lines have awkward wording about having little to do except talk.]]
 At times they grew more confidential
 as their spirits became livelier.
 Some significant things were said,
 which, by the way, were very good.
 I did not like the style of compliments
[[an awkward phrase about remarks from near a fence]],

but I do not think anyone meant
to offend anyone else.

There were two widows there,
whom the speaker calls ugly and very fat,
unable to claim beauty
except in their past.

They eyed the young men and talked
in a way peculiarly their own,
but could sit around or walk
while remaining entirely alone.
Then there were the handsome teenage girls,
[[*uncertain verb*]] about,
seemingly made for hugs and kisses,
which a fellow might secretly get, I suppose.

Reading note. The speaker's disparaging judgments are retained and attributed to him. The poem identifies no individual in these descriptions.

Scan 088 10-088

The camp meeting poem on flattery and courtship

How affectionate they looked, so coy and sly,
their bright eyes glancing about,
as though saying, "If you only try,
you may get kisses, with a pout!"
By hokey, if I politely encounter
the lucky young devil
clever enough to get a few kisses,
I will try to follow his example.
I will be all smiles and attention,
noticing their smallest needs,
doing everything courtesy could suggest,
and thinking of everything it cannot.
I will always lift my hat respectfully
when I speak to them,
and show the greatest preference
for whatever catches their fancy.
To please them in a loving mood,
I will tell them scores of lies;
if that does no good,
I will tell twice as many more.
If their brows gently reproach me,
I will immediately take back everything I said,
and become so affectionate and loving
that they will shower me with blessings [[*ending phrase unclear*]].
In short, I will bend like a willow

to every slight breath of wind,
and do everything possible
to rest my head upon their kind bosoms!

But I know there are some irritable creatures
who long ago lost their lovely features—

Reading note. Continues at 10-089. The manipulative courtship boasts are reproduced as satire, without endorsement or biographical inference.

Scan 089 10-089

The camp meeting speaker answers his imagined critics

—who will criticize me severely
for everything I have sincerely said here.
They will suspiciously say, “He is a devilish scamp,
and an outrageous one at that.
The girls should not permit such behavior;
they should dismiss him immediately!”
If some people say this, I can only reply
that on life’s rough road they have never known
the glorious pleasure and delighted bliss
surrounding an affectionate kiss.
They are the sort an old tale describes,
lacking attractive charms and gentle graces,
who have traveled through life alone,
unacquainted with social pleasure and great happiness.
[[An awkward phrase refers to Cythera’s? welcoming shores.]]
They have picked no fruit from its splendid bowers,
but let everything wither beneath a hateful sun
until their nobler feelings disappeared.
Now they stand at life’s edge,
singing a mournful complaint against youth and happiness.

But when we meet a beautiful girl,
the pride and envy of the world,
whose unmatched beauty and perfect grace
show in every feature of face and form,
whose raven hair falls from a high, classical brow
around a snow-white neck,
and whose shining soul looks freely out
through deep, lustrous dark eyes—
whoever can see all these charms combined
without feeling Cupid’s arrow—

Reading note. Several irregular sentences are smoothed for readability. The reference transcript preserves them and marks the uncertain name.

Scan 090 10-090

The camp meeting poem concludes with an imagined embrace

—has a soul dead to everything lovely and dear.

[[An awkward line concerns harsh circumstances and the absence of a tear.]]

He will sink into an unhonored grave,
a fitting end to his life's deep gloom.

Ah, when I meet a fair young woman
with "azure eyes and golden hair,"
well-formed limbs and a springing step,
dimpled cheeks and a delicate head,
sunny smiles, graceful charms,
and noble bearing, my heart warms
with all those pure, sweet desires
that love so often inspires.
When I clasp her willing hand
in an ardent, affectionate grip,
and gently draw to my breast
the person who holds my deepest feelings,
meet the glance of her soul-lit eye,
and hear her short but deep sigh,
while her waving hair falls backward
from her lovely, pursed lips,
and with a sweet caress
she presses her living lips to mine,
affection beyond control
rushes through the depths of my soul.
Those wild, enchanting delights suggest
that the whole world exists in this moment.

September 1866.

Reading note. A modern rendering of the poem's figurative, sometimes awkward language. The kiss is narrated as an imagined or generalized experience; no partner is identified.

Scan 091 10-091

Idle Hours on lost hopes and storms

Idle Hours

I can watch the storm for hours
and listen to the deep-voiced thunder,
rolling majestically across the sky
where everything was once peaceful and quiet.

I feel a wild kinship
with these fierce scenes of conflict,

now that my calmer peace has vanished
in the harsh blasts of early life.

My sky was once clear and bright blue,
and every hope promised pleasure.
Now everything is dull and dreary,
and my dearest hopes lie withered in the grave.

What once was covered with lovely flowers,
where the sweetest fruit seemed to lie ahead,
when pleasure gave wings to golden hours
and everything seemed light, life, and joy,
spread brightly along my path—
that shining vision of happiness,
filled with bliss, lay before me
in one long line of gleaming light.

I scarcely imagined this dark hour,
when I would seek peace in the fiercest conflict,
or thought I would submit to the dark power
that has blighted my early life.

Reading note. Concludes at 10-092. The imagery expresses sorrow but does not identify its cause.

Scan 092 10-092

Idle Hours concluded and memories of an oasis in life

But so it is. With a hardened heart,
I face the world without fearing its scorn,
still knowing I can bear my part,
though the thorn presses deeper into my breast.

Seclusion, August 23, 1866.

A second poem

Looking back through the years,
I see a single oasis in my early life,
beautifully green and filled with flowers,
clothed in rare, rich brightness.
Sunshine played over every happy scene,
and enchanting beauties cast a silver glow
through the spring air, a bright contrast
to life's surrounding wasteland of sorrow.

Carefree, I wandered its glorious paths.
Among the lovely bowers, innocent birds
sang still sweeter, soul-stirring songs,
adding music's happiness to each clear, winding way.
Dazzled by the beautiful scenes around me,
I thought they would always be plentiful:

that, as I followed life's wandering course,
 such lovely bowers would always arch
 across my path, lending their brightest colors
 to create gentle delight and quiet happiness.

But the glowing spectacle quickly passed,
 and life's dreary wasteland lay before me.
 Its scorching sands stretched into the distance,
 where hatred's fierce desert winds lifted them,
 burying beneath their burning force
 every noble feeling that happened to wander there.
 In the deserted heart where once stood
 all the generous instincts of goodness,
 no hope of pleasure now remains
 except the sad memory: "It can never come again!"

January 14, 1867. George Douglas.

A separate marginal verse

There is a loneliness of the heart
 that words can never express,
 too deep for sorrow's tears
 to relieve the aching breast:
 a joyless, motionless, *[[uncertain adjective]]* wasteland,
 all dark, dreary, and abandoned,
 where every lovely flower placed upon it
 conceals a poisonous thorn.

G. D.

Reading note. The three pieces and their dates are kept separate. The sorrow is real as literary expression; its biographical cause is not supplied here.

Scan 093 10-093

The anonymous courtship poem resumes with Seclusion

Continued from manuscript page 9

But amid all this confusion,
 what has become of "Seclusion"?
 I saw him on the Fourth of July,
 slipping about rather slyly,
 looking first at one person, then another,
 just like a fellow at a loss.
 And listen, stars above:
 I saw him close beside Miss McFarland.
 At that time, I have also "heard tell,"
 he was seen fanning Miss Maggie Bell.

Still, I say your efforts are useless *[[unusual term of address]]*.
 You may look around yourselves
 and try to discover my hidden identity.
 I fire safely from behind a log,
 striking them a few more times
 until they fume as never before.
 I do not care; let them fret and roar
 and shout until their throats are sore.
 My only satisfaction
 is watching my fellow mortals rage.

But I felt enormously flattered
[[an awkward line about praise spread over these pages]],
 when I was sagely declared
 the greatest poet of the modern age.

When I first heard this lofty praise
 of my talents, a glorious vision
 of undying fame and heavenly delight
 shot unerringly through my heart—

Reading note. Continues at 10-094. “Seclusion” is a character label here; the poem does not give his full name.

Scan 094 10-094

The comic poet's disappointed hopes for Kitty and Laura

—making me feel like a modern Pope
 and hope for everlasting honors.

But you, before whom poets bow
 with heartfelt devotion,
 will you listen now
 while I tell a sad story?
 My loving heart is finally broken
 “because no one will love me,”
 even though the words I spoke
 were inspired from above.

Once I thought I would write a little song
 to handsome, pleasant little Kitty.
 But as I began to write the lines,
 along came Samuel Pace,
 whose earnest gestures
 ruined all my fine calculations.
 So I had to seek another bower
 and try my magic power again—
 which, as everyone has clearly proved,
 is not so magical after all.

Next I saw Pleasant Hill,
 still blooming in all its glory.
 I thought I could never be unhappy
 while lovely Laura smiled there.
 So, using all my skill,
 I bound up my shattered heart
 and dressed it in the happiest smiles
 ever seen upon the earth—

Reading note. Continues at 10-095. The poem's comic romantic narrative is not used to establish family relationships.

Scan 095 10-095

Sammy wins Laura in the poem's mock campaign

—and thought to offer at her altar
 a love that would never waver.
 But alas for my plans:
 how rivals ruin them!

At last there came
 backward, bashful, modest Sam,
 who pressed his suit so eagerly
 that I seriously considered gunpowder.
 But I knew that ruining him
 would also be my own undoing,
 so I behaved fairly.
 Sammy won dear Laura's heart,
 leaving me like a newly shorn lamb,
 out in the cold to mourn my loss.

I could bow before the "Delphine Shrine"
 and plead my case passionately now,
 but I have no desire
 to charge strong Prospect Hill.
 Two generals are entrenched there,
 in the hearts of the lovely women.
 A poor corporal has no chance
 to drive them out with spear or lance.
 He must lift the siege at once
 and seek another, nearer allegiance.

Wherever I go, where could I find
 anyone more suited to my mind
 than you, fair young woman, whose pure love
 is gently distilled from above—

Reading note. Continues at 10-096. The military language is used for humorous romantic rivalry; it does not provide a military service history.

Scan 096 10-096

The courtship poem ends with a plea and two epigrams

—the noble feelings given to your heart
are affections that have wandered down from heaven.

[[The next couplet has awkward wording about nature's gifts]]:

your heart receives a divine gift directly.

Can it be wrong for me to seek
the love I scarcely dare mention?

No: what is given to mortals
should be theirs, even if it comes from heaven.

July 30, 1866.

Two separate short verses

If still waters truly
indicate a deep pool,
I suppose an unmarried woman's chatter
must indicate a very shallow one.

“Married life is a great source of happiness,”
would-be clever fools imagine.
But I think they will soon change their minds
when they receive a bedtime scolding!

Reading note. The epigrams contain the writer's disparaging humor. They do not establish his marital status or the identities of people mentioned earlier in the poem.

Scan 097 10-097

Idle Hours on childhood innocence

Idle Hours

The first, dearest, purest hopes
of life's bright, sunny hour
bloom freshly within a small world,
like a bright flower in spring.

The growing mind then glows
beneath a kindly sun,
and bright joys continually flow,
yet all come from a single source.

That source is innocent simplicity,
expressed by the infant's heart,
breathing like sweet, sacred incense
upon its mother's breast.

Angels hover over its path
on distant spiritual wings,

turning aside every harmful ray
that might spoil its purity.

They weep over each wayward thought
that arises in its mind,
fearing that all its divine loveliness
might come to nothing.

But alas, what are angels' tears?
What can they accomplish
when, through the troubles of later years,
we read the heart's sad story?

Reading note. Continues at 10-098. This is a philosophical poem, not evidence of a specific childhood or death.

Scan 098 10-098

Idle Hours concludes with grief for lost innocence

It tells of hopes once bright, now faded and gone,
with happier hours behind them,
leaving the heart a hardened stone
and every spring of affection dry.

Disappointment is written too deeply
upon life's dreary page.
Earlier joys are struck down forever,
withering as age advances.

Life is empty, sorrow stamped
upon a wrinkled brow,
and memory embittered and weighed down
by scenes of past unhappiness.

Dark despair still hovers
over the shattered human wreck.
On time's shore, hope can offer
no ray to encourage him again.

What use, then, are angels' tears,
if we must suffer this way
and harvest, year after year,
successive fields of sorrow?

Oh, the speaker says, it is better in childhood
to find an early grave
and return to heaven, still undimmed,
the jewel that heaven gave.

Seclusion, August 26, 1866.

Reading note. The final stanza's bleak claim belongs to the poem's speaker. It does not identify a deceased child.

Scan 099 10-099

Idle Hours at sunset beside a stream

Idle Hours

The sun was sinking in the west
 into a deep blue sky.
 Nature slowly retired to rest,
 singing its music high above.
 I left a cozy fireside
 and wandered alone in a thoughtful mood,
 down near a murmuring stream
 beside a deep, solitary wood.
 Hot passions fired my heart,
 racing ahead of my senses.
 Ambition urged me to win the woman I admired,
 and gain her heart as my desired reward:
 a wreath of beauty still far away
 on life's uncertain sea,
 yet no less a glorious star
 though hidden by deep uncertainty.

I traced my winding course
 down life's future road toward that prize,
 where I could lay my heartfelt burden
 of love before her soul-lit eyes.

It is sweet to look down time's current
 and see awaiting glories shine,
 to hear their voices harmonize
 and imagine their combined beauty as mine.
 It is sweet to think I may win
 a heart to cheer my weary journey,
 though dark hours come between us,
 like the monotonous gloom of a starless night.

The manuscript directs the reader to page 52.

Reading note. Continue this poem at 10-112–10-113, as directed by the manuscript. No woman is named on this page.

Scan 100 10-100

An apology to Miss M L G for the anonymous rhymes

To Miss M. L. G.

All through the long day, among the crowd,
 I sat patiently listening to the thunderous words
 of a long sermon addressed to sinners,
 kept in the heat without their dinners.

Fasting may be good for Christian people,
 but feed the sinners if you want them to stay until the end,
 lest they become restless and run away
 without receiving salvation that day.

But saint, sinner, and the kindly preacher
 all vanished from my thoughts
 when quiet, idle whispers
 ran through the crowded gathering.

They said you were terribly offended
 by an anonymous communication,
 served up in rhyme
[[an unclear line about its being forwarded three times]].

You thought the author of the noisy rhymes
 had certainly gone too far
 and, in his simple little song,
 had laid it on much too strongly.

I am misfortune's favorite child,
 for all my noblest hopes are frustrated.
[[An awkward line describes my passionate nature.]]
 I fondly write down my sentimental thoughts,
 yet whenever I strike the lyre—

Reading note. Continues at 10-101. Difficult wording is flagged rather than replaced with an invented fluent line.

Scan 101 10-101

The anonymous poet offers an apology

—I always overshoot the mark.

I throw every passion into one effort
 and try to reach the goal in one bold leap.
 That is how I ruin my dearest hopes:
 by moving just a little too quickly.

I am extremely sorry and would apologize
 for writing to you in this way,
 if I knew how—but I cannot claim
 the honor of approaching you by name.

If I thought I could win some of your favor,
 I would abandon my disguise
 and rush into your presence, almost overcome by fear,
 to plead my case like a lawyer in court.

I would not need to retract my words
 and replace them with the whole truth,

unless I added a new compliment
 blended with still deeper feelings.

I would not hurt your feelings for the world
 —allow me to make an exception for one lovely girl.
 I would humbly, humbly apologize
 and hope to see forgiveness in your eyes.

When I next write to you,
 I will choose a nobler theme
 and call upon the nine Muses
 to descend and refine my vulgar thoughts.

August 15, 1866.

Reading note. The apology remains playful and retains an unexplained exception involving “one lovely girl.” No identity is assigned to her.

Scan 102 10-102

Invocation dedicated to Miss M L Green perhaps

Respectfully inscribed to Miss M. L. *[[Green?]]*

Invocation

Come, heavenly sisterhood of Muses,
 from the heights of Parnassus.
 Come with inspiration's starry torch
 and rekindle my pen.
 Let heaven's refined thoughts
 flash through my heart and inspire my mind
 with all the pure, bright feelings
 that come from the source of light.
 Let no corrupting thought mingle its power
 with these true words I dedicate to a friend.
 Let the noblest feelings ever held
 in a human heart descend from the stars.
 May their long journey never dim
 the imprint of heaven's radiant light.
 Let them glow as wonderfully fair
 as they did in their native star,
 before baser passions taught the human heart
 to lie or practice deception.

Yes, pure friendship deserves a nobler offering
 than earthly treasure can provide:
 something pure that flows from heart to heart,
 which cleverness and all its schemes cannot give.
 It bears the soul's imprint,
 which one friend may honestly reveal to another.

On the shrine of fair friendship,
I now place this simple offering—

Reading note. Continues at 10-103. The surname in the dedication is tentative; it should not yet be added to the family tree as certain.

Scan 103 10-103

Trust as the strongest bond of friendship

—trust, the first flower in love's wreath,
which I give as a gift from above,
inspired by heaven and your spotless truth,
the noblest gift a young person can possess.
Accept it, for it contains
the strongest links in friendship's sacred bonds.

Then the pleasures of companionship will live again
and reign within our hearts.

Base slander, thrown from its high seat
into the dust and trampled underfoot,
will never again rise in a hideous form
to shake our trust or spoil our warm happiness.
Those joys will follow one another for years,
claiming their birthright from the skies.
They will continue through successive ages,
the light of life and the soul's enduring strength,
growing stronger through the years,
erasing dark doubts and driving away gloomy fears.

They are a cure for every human sorrow
that the reluctant future may reveal,
leaving nature in its purest state.
Even when high pulses and racing blood,
driven by conflicting passions,
banish mercy from the heart and defy heaven,
heaven still holds pure, deep feelings
that need no coarse support *[[wording uncertain in sense]]*.
May they sustain, through our journey to life's end,
thoughts that are noble, divine, deep, bright, and serene.

Seclusion, August 21, 1866.

Reading note. This is a modern rendering of the poem's argument about trust and friendship. Irregular wording is preserved in the reference transcript.

Scan 104 10-104

Written on the death of Robert D Andrews

Written on the Death of Robert D. Andrews

I stood beside his lifeless body
and his breast enclosed in a coffin,
and saw yesterday's hopes
dressed in death's clothing.

I heard the solemn funeral service,
the last tribute to the noble dead,
who lay shrouded in white.

"His mortal body lies before us;
his spirit has departed.
His voice will no longer warm our hearts,
for he is dead.

Though he is gone and we shall see
our loved one no more,
One has gone before him
to heaven above.

That One carried the shameful cross
on Calvary.

He rejects only the worthless remainder
of our mortal existence.

The soul, the jewel heaven gave,
so pure and bright,
will pass safely beyond the grave
into realms of light.

We may meet at their threshold
and never part again.

Those we have loved will warmly greet us
upon that shore—

Reading note. Continues at 10-105–10-106. This is a named memorial poem, but its composition date should not be substituted for Andrews's death date.

Scan 105 10-105

A friend and companion of the poet's youth

Slowly the spotless shroud
wrapped its folds around him.

Then affection's beloved one
was laid deep beneath the ground.

Friend and companion of my youth,
though death has come,
it could not destroy the beautiful truth
that carried you home.

Though we will never meet again on earth,
your memory will remain sacred,
even in my most carefree hours.

"Though I pursue life's wild course,

as restless as the waves,”
 I will pause to shed friendship’s affectionate tear
 upon your grave.
 When spring returns in bright beauty
 and clothes the trees,
 the rose will release its sweet perfume
 upon the breeze.
 Daisies will bloom sweetly
 in the green meadow,
 and nature’s wild music
 will flow joyfully.
 We will no longer share
 these beautiful scenes,
 for every earthly pleasure
 has passed away from you.
 We will no longer greet the morning together,
 when sweet songs rise to heaven
 on fragrant winds,
 a fitting offering—

Reading note. The writer explicitly describes Andrews as a friend and youthful companion. No further relationship is inferred.

Scan 106 10-106

George Douglas’s farewell to Andrews and Ad idem

—to nature’s God, who rules the universes
 from above in purity,
 through the laws of love
 for all eternity.
 We will no longer hear those raptures rise with you
 or ascend heavenward
 through their clear inspiration.
 You have gone beyond death’s darkness
 to dwell in heaven,
 and I can only breathe over your grave
 a final farewell.

Seclusion, December 24, 1866.

George Douglas.

On the Same Subject

Come with me to a lonely graveyard,
 where oak trees wave their stately branches,
 sunshine lies on the soft green turf,
 and daisies bloom in beauty.

There brightly winged birds
sing their sweetest notes in the nearby forest.
The heart, softened by quiet reflection,
rises toward heaven through deeply sorrowful tears.

Come and kneel beside a newly made mound,
where violets have never yet bloomed.
Bend low over the damp, cold earth,
where someone who died young lies deeply buried.

Reading note. The second poem continues at 10-107 and has its own date. Its placement and “Ad idem” connect it to the preceding memorial, but neither poem names the cemetery.

Scan 107 10-107

Ad idem concludes with Courtesy and truth

Shed a tear here with the brokenhearted,
who remain to mourn those loved and lost,
and cherished hopes defeated by death’s
blighting, untimely frost.

Weep affectionately over broken bonds
woven in life’s bright early spring.
Weep for the one who now lies low,
where his suffering heart can no longer mourn.

His hopes, joys, and prospects have passed
as quickly as morning dew.
That heart was too bright to endure
the withering scenes of the coming day.

Weep sincerely for the one who has gone,
for tears refine the softened soul.
As each pearly drop flows,
the heart gently opens to receive the divine.

Weep sincerely, for the heavenly record
against a heart stained by earthly sin
is gently removed by the deep sigh,
winning back the joy of reconciliation with heaven.

Weep sincerely: it is a fitting tribute
to the companion of our early youth,
noble, devoted, and true,
whose ardent motto was “Courtesy and truth.”

January 5, 1867.

Geo. D.

Reading note. This companion elegy follows the named memorial to Robert D. Andrews. The January date belongs to the poem and is not evidence of the date of death.

Scan 108 10-108

Varying Moments from delight to darkness

Varying Moments

There are moments when we wander
among imagination's delights,
gently inspired by a nobler love
and absorbed in joyful song.

There are moments when we give
our purest, noblest thoughts
to the higher purpose for which we live,
a purpose bought for us with blood.

Those moments shine with a gentle delight
unknown to darker hours,
shedding a bright but passing light
upon our dark road.

They foreshadow a happier day
of peace and quiet rest,
when we may wander in lovelier fields,
blessed by sunshine and flowers.

Then the growing soul will breathe
the fragrance of purer joys
than those that now surround us,
mixed with the coarser elements of passion.

But all too soon those visions
of brighter days have passed.
Darker moments quickly gather,
with no sunbeam passing through them.

Reading note. Continues at 10-109. The poem speaks in general terms about changing moods and spiritual hope.

Scan 109 10-109

Varying Moments questions human systems of thought

These are moments of deep, dark bitterness,
when every higher purpose withers:
purposes that rise spark by spark
from a lone, dying flame.

Such bitter moments freeze the soul
and constrain its warm desires,
yet roll onward
like fierce, consuming fires.

People feed them with their wild "isms,"
which torment the mind and overwhelm the senses,

leading every trusting child astray
who does not know who steers the ship.

Humanity, you who try to lead the way
through life's temptations,
can you shed a ray of heavenly light
and tell us what it means?

Can you brighten the darkened spirit,
remove every burden of care,
and give us lasting, radiant hopes
while we wander here?

Do your systems not blur every page
of the light given to us?
Do they not multiply with age
and shut out heaven's light?

June 14, 1867.
Geo. D.

Reading note. The family version gives the apparent sense of one irregular line about a heavenly ray. The exact wording remains in the reference transcript.

Scan 110 10-110

An album as a keepsake of absent friends
For an Album

In youth we treasure sacred bonds
formed in life's bright, cheerful morning,
like garlands gathered before the dew dries
from beauty's smile, which will pass too soon.

We weave them into a pure, fragrant wreath
and lay it on the heart in friendship's name.
Then we see how quickly death's dark wings
sweep away the flowers we loved as our own.

In later days we sadly weep alone
over those withered jewels of earlier years,
which lead memory back to departed loved ones
who left us lonely and in tears.

These treasures are virtuous thoughts
written on an album's untouched page
by youth's carefree heart, before sorrow pursues it
or death claims it for instruction.

So I casually scatter across this page
some idle thoughts that may someday recall

to your memory someone you knew,
who perhaps fell all too soon.

Perhaps a solitary tear will start from your eye
as you remember his unhappy life,
and a deep sigh will escape your tender heart
to mingle with that gently flowing tear.

February 1867.

Reading note. An album verse about memory and anticipated loss. Its imagined future death is not a dated death record.

Scan 111 10-111

Farewell to Irene

Song

Farewell, Irene: the hour of parting
has come, and I must go.
But memory will gladly wander back
to you, my cherished flower.
Broken hopes around me
speak of brighter scenes now gone,
and brighter prospects slowly dying
warn of sorrow still to come.

Farewell, Irene! We may never
meet again while we live “above.”
But time’s scythe cannot cut
my loved one from my heart.

I regret leaving you, Irene,
and breaking every sacred bond
that has wound like green ivy
around virtue’s charms.
Pleasant hopes flourish
only to die amid conflict.
Fate has frowned darkly between us,
blighting my early life.

I will wander the earth alone,
far from scenes I loved too well,
seeking merriment among pleasure’s crowds
to restrain sorrow’s rising tide.
Scenes of the past, fade away!
Let new hopes charm my heart.
Let me wander carelessly, recklessly onward,
heedless of anything that threatens harm.

February 1867.

Reading note. A literary farewell addressed to Irene. The page does not establish her identity or whether the song recounts the writer's own experience.

Scan 112 10-112

Idle Hours continued in imagination's fields

Continued from manuscript page 39

It is sweet to wander through imagination's fields
among her beautiful flowers,
where glowing thoughts yield rich treasures
brightly through successive hours.

It is sweet to commune affectionately
with wild, free nature,
and feel the magic influence of her wand:
imagination's boundless world of ideals.

Imagination, source of my sweetest joys,
I offer you my heart's homage.
No corruption spoils your brightest visions
with the deceptive stains of dark reality.
You lead me far into cheerful fields
where endless summers shine.
You give my heart the sweetest joys,
which grow sweeter the more I taste them.

Patron goddess of my happier hours,
I love to wander with you.
You scatter the fairest, sweetest flowers
along my thorn-lined, winding path.
My visions, clothed in sweet fragrances,
leap forward across lovely sunny landscapes,
blessed by beauty's brightest smiles
and rare, exquisite loveliness.
The gnawing cares of fact disappear
before your approaching, lovely face.
You banish their hideous forms to oblivion
and make a glowing place for unsullied joy.
Welcome, then: hand in hand we will wander
down time's twisting stream—

Reading note. This resumes 10-099 and continues at 10-113. The text personifies imagination and contrasts it with the cares of fact.

Scan 113 10-113

Idle Hours concluded and a later satire

Idle Hours, conclusion

And gather, as we pass each bend,
its sweetest joys to mingle in our verse.
January 5, 1867. Geo. D.

Separate satire, May 1869

Alas, my old flame has faded.
The bloom has gone from her cheek,
and not one beautiful tress
now shades her classical brow.
Her step is dull and lifeless
as she pines in her old maid's bed.

The light has left her eye
like a star's gleam lost in fog.
Instead of sighing poetically with a broken heart,
she simply grunts like a hog.
The music has long gone from her voice;
she can no longer breathe affection's sigh.

She calmly marches through life
with her old man beside her.
She sometimes has plenty to say
to make the old fellow provide
for her and the little "graces"
now gathering around with surly faces.

May 1869.

Reading note. The first poem ends here. The second is an unkind literary satire with no named subject; it is not reliable biographical evidence about the writer or his family.

Scan 114 10-114

Farewell to earthly joys, addressed to Miss M. A. A.

Respectfully inscribed to Miss M. A. A.

Farewell, joys of earth, farewell.
We must part at life's threshold.
I will not try your enticing spell again
or risk a broken heart.

Farewell, joys: a long farewell!
I now claim no pleasures.
I have learned too well how fleeting you are;
I have learned that you exist in name alone.

I still speak "farewell" with sadness.
Your visions drew me onward too far.
They still vibrate on memory's chord
and gently bring a glistening tear.

It is wrong to mourn the fading
of visions that were false, yet bright.
But without you, life's dark road
is only a weary, weary night.

Shall I seek imagination's bright gleam
to light my dark road,
sparkling like a meteor
in the darkness of night?

It shines brilliantly from far away,
a beacon raised on high,
like the glorious morning star
shining in an early sky.

Reading note. Continues at 10-115. The family rendering gives the apparent sense of the faded line about fleeting joy; the uncertain word is marked in the reference transcript.

Scan 115 10-115

Imagination offers relief from sorrow

Yes, I may seek that beautiful ray
and welcome its brightness for a while,
to shine on my lonely, dark road
with its bright, illusory smile.

While that brilliant beam shines,
my soul leaps forward along its path.
Thought swiftly follows those burning lines
across the uncharted reaches of space.

Then, visions, your power
holds my spirit captive.
Your bright illusions rule the hour,
and my breaking heart no longer bleeds.

I catch imagination's glorious ray,
which casts those dreams of wild delight.
For a while my dark road
shines beautifully in radiant light.

Then little flowers release sweet perfumes
from countless fragrant gardens.
Pleasure's wand lights with hope
each *[[unreadable word]]* moment of the golden hours.

Fragrant breezes *[[unreadable word or words]]* wander
among those imagined fields,
carrying swiftly from every sacred grove
its spicy fragrance.

Reading note. Continues 10-114. Unreadable wording remains marked; the next scan begins another poem.

Scan 116 10-116

Visit to Siloam

Visit to Siloam

It was on the first of Brumaire—
 I like to be precise about time,
 so whenever or wherever I go,
 I will remember the occasion for my verse.
 It was on the first of Brumaire,
 as I was about to say,
 that I brushed my shoes and smoothed my hair,
 promising myself a happy day.
 A fresh, fair west wind blew,
 soon dispersing the morning clouds.
 As I faced the invigorating air,
 I breathed in its wild, free spirit.

I mounted a trotting horse
 and hurried through the mud,
 heading toward Siloam
 with poetry running through my head.
 At last I reached its grounds
 and tied my horse to a tree.
 I looked around at the arrangements
 and at whatever there was to see.
 My heart beat high with joyful hope;
 everything seemed promising.
 I considered my prospects with satisfaction
 and passed the sunny hours hopefully.
 Stumbling through the leafy shade,
 over heaps of logs and an occasional slab,
 I found some old companions
 having a private conversation.

Reading note. Continues at 10-117. The source calls the date “the first of Brumaire”; no calendar conversion or identification of Siloam is asserted.

Scan 117 10-117

Siloam companions and courtship banter

“Hello, companions! Are you here?
 I greet you warmly,
 but cannot see why you would travel
 so far from home merely for a meeting.
 I rather suspect
 some stronger motive:

an emotion set fully in motion
by Cupid's laws."

At last Prospect Hill spoke slowly:
"You are right about the emotion.
Assign it to whichever laws you please;
it brings us no 'motion.'
I hear the young women of our shrine
are coming to Siloam today.
I will claim one graceful girl;
you may wander freely with the rest."

As he spoke, I watched closely
the changing expressions on their faces,
which wrinkled up like a stick
notched in half a dozen places.

Then Prospect Junior smiled and replied:
"I came here to Siloam
to draw up beside the gray pony
and quietly escort him home."

I answered, "May no harm come to you!
I would not do that for money,
for you are sure to ride home
with a parson's sweetheart."

Reading note. The playful aliases are not expanded into real identities. One irregular line is smoothed in the family version. A continuous next passage has not been securely identified.

Scan 118 10-118

Sorrow over interrupted social pleasures, and Love

No pen can describe the depth of our sorrow
since that curtain strayed from the regions of darkness.

Storm of sorrow spread across our sky,
may the sunshine of gentleness disperse your gloom,
so we may once more look far upward
where our bright stars light the social heavens.

Then all the happiness we desire will return:
permission to offer our devotion again
at the shrine we love. We could ask no greater
pleasure in this lowly world of pain.

Flow on, bright waters. I will no longer sing
the tale of our sorrows to your crystal clarity.
Perhaps future years will bring brighter hours,
and we may (?) rest sweetly in pleasure's lap.

Geo. D. Seclusion, November 4, 1866.

Separate verse

Love is a fragrant flowering bud
that delights the young for a while.
They gaze at its rosy blush
while their pulse is high and pleasure strong.
But its glowing beauty does not please for long;
their eyes soon turn to more lasting attractions.
The fickle goddess sings a farewell
and dies in pure friendship's arms.

December 1866. Geo. D.

Reading note. The first passage starts in the middle of a poem. Its relationship to the preceding Siloam verses is possible, but not certain. The question mark in "may (?)" belongs to the manuscript.

Scan 119 10-119

To Miss Mat. A. on truth and affection

To Miss Mat. A.

As I gaze affectionately, with shining eyes,
at your thoughtful, calm, pure brow,
I see, with clear prophetic inspiration,
pure features that have wandered from paradise.

They have alighted on this stormy world,
still blooming beautifully in steadfast purity:
the loveliest gift heaven could ever offer
from the vast reaches of its immensity.

That gift is truth; heaven is its giver.
You, fair girl, are its recipient:
the noblest gift bestowed on any mortal
who has lived in this humble world.

July 1866. Geo. D.

To the same

Remembering our last meeting
still fills my heart with pleasure.
I will never, never forget you,
my only treasure.

The feelings that then thrilled my heart,
holy and pure but unspoken,
still burn and will not rest,
forming bonds never to be broken.

These are bonds of pure affection,
unstained by the dark mixture of hidden designs,

as pure as has ever been achieved,
as pure as the purest earthly joy.

Reading note. The second poem continues at 10-120. “Mat. A.” is the manuscript’s form; no full identity is asserted.

Scan 120 10-120

Enduring affection and two irreverent epitaphs

Fair maiden, you do not know the bond
that winds around my heart each hour.
You do not know the feelings buried there,
deep within love. *[[The original wording is irregular; this is its apparent sense.]]*

These feelings will linger long
after youth’s bloom has faded,
still glowing brightly and strongly,
though darkened by age.

December 1866. Geo. D.

Epitaph

Come near and shed a pious tear
beside this memorial stone.
The bones now decaying here
were once a mighty living bore.

Epigram

What a pity that people waste
so much good time on a stone,
only to set it at last
above a thoroughly rotten bone!

Reading note. The first poem continues 10-119. The two epitaphs are anonymous satires, not records of a named person’s death.

Scan 121 10-121

Hours of Bitterness: remembered pleasures

Hours of Bitterness

There are moments when the past
comes over me like a dream:
scenes of youth, too bright to last,
which cast *[[unreadable wording]]* a flickering gleam
of happiness over my saddened heart.
No ray of light now enters there
to give a moment’s joy
without fading in that very instant.
I have reached for pleasure’s lively company
as it swept past in swift groups.

I have mingled in its wildest boasting,
 my pulse beating madly and high.
 I have seen its attractions spread before me
 in a bright, distant succession.
 I have felt its influence lead me
 from star to star of beauty,
 which shone brightly as queen
 of every idle heart that blindly knelt
 among her brilliant followers,
 at the center of cheerful folly's marketplace.
 I have seen smiles of eager joy
 play on rosy lips,
 untainted by deceit's dark influence,
 drinking from hope's sweet fountains.
 I have seen fond, loving eyes
 meet eyes that returned their love.
 I have heard the first, gentlest sigh
 of a heart struck down by Cupid.
 I have felt the hopes that quicken the blood
 when future joys appear—

Reading note. Continues at 10-122. The poem's speaker describes remembered emotions; unnamed romantic figures are not assigned identities.

Scan 122 10-122

Hours of Bitterness: hopes that vanish

I have felt a more cheerful mood
 when songs of revelry were heard.
 But what were those pleasures? A bright moment,
 a minute like a flickering spark
 that leaps upward from a lonely light,
 then dies, leaving everything twice as dark.

I have seen life's hopes decay
 before the morning dew dried.
 I have felt my joys lie low and withering,
 like garlands in a vast desert.
 Everything I loved with a trusting heart,
 everything I hoped for in early days,
 I have seen quickly depart before me
 like dew beneath the morning sun.
 I tried to capture those pearly drops
 and keep them in my heart,
 hoping their innocent purity
 would inspire a gentler spirit.
 I tried to gather fragrant flowers

blooming along my path,
 to entwine with happier hours
 and weave into joyful song.
 Before I could touch them, those bright drops
 fled like morning mist
 when the sun's bold, shining light
 announced the arrival of day.
 Those fragrant flowers of loveliness,
 like snowflakes upon the sea,
 rested for an instant on my breast,
 then increased its storminess.

Reading note. Read next at 10-123, whose scan is upside down.

Scan 123 10-123

Hours of Bitterness: loneliness and lost hopes

Wherever I turn for lasting attractions,
 wherever I look with brighter hopes,
 nothing warms my heart
 or opens its deep fountain.
 I have tried in vain to win
 purity's priceless jewels,
 to wrest them from adversity
 and light my earthly path.
 I have plunged deeper into the dark recesses
 of the soul's night,
 only to find that nothingness
 lay inside its dreary gates:
 a chaotic void filled with gloom
 and dark, storm-driven passions,
 where light and beauty can never enter,
 nor a single breath of heaven stray.

The dark thoughts tormenting the mind!
 When threatening hours of loneliness
 hover around me, they leave feelings
 I can never express.
 Bright early scenes and visions
 fade like morning dew.
 Hopes that shed a holy light
 like heaven's kindly ray
 also perish amid the wreck
 of human aims, which "dying fall,"
 meeting no restraint as they descend
 to save them all from total ruin.

I have turned and wept to see them go
and leave my heart completely desolate.

Reading note. Continues from 10-122 to 10-124. These are poetic expressions of loneliness.

Scan 124 10-124

Hours of Bitterness asks where relief can be found

I would bring those hopes back now—but, oh,
this is fate's relentless hand.

Who can change its stern decrees
once the seal has been set?

We must submit, though robbed of ease,
and learn to suffer further sorrow.

When will the cup of sorrow be full?

When will misery's demon rest?

When will dejection stop pulling
contentment from the weary heart?

When will oblivion's gloomy shadows
wrap the past in endless night?

When will the darkened fiends of Hades
stop dimming the spirit's light?

Can we expect no hours
of sunshine and bright relief?

Are there no guides to lead
a heart away from the lasting grief

of dying hopes, before life
has even begun in earnest on earth,

before the spirit has halfway attained
the form of that which gave it birth?

Are there no scenes that might bloom
toward life's dismal closing days,

shedding a rich fragrance of sweetness
in its dying confusion?

Are there no joys to fill the heart,
no purer hours given to us,

before we find the final rest
prepared for some in heaven?

It seems the whole earth is dark
and we are blind wanderers below—

Reading note. Continues at 10-125. "Some" in the line about heaven is the writer's inserted revision, replacing "us."

Scan 125 10-125

Hours of Bitterness: a voice promises rest

Traveling—where? Without a sign
 by which we could surely find our way,
 traveling through doubt and gloom,
 through gnawing cares on every side.
 Conflicts loom behind and ahead,
 their murky tide rolling darkly.
 In vain we look eagerly around
 for peace and sweet rest,
 hoping amid surrounding sorrow
 to see a ray of pleasure rise.
 Every distant scene promising
 happiness in future days
 lives faintly in imagination alone
 and passes like summer haze.
 For one bright moment it shines far away,
 with changing brilliance above,
 glowing like a meteor
 in the blackness of the sky.
 Just as quickly, it disappears
 in the stillness of night,
 and hope retreats as swiftly
 as it advanced toward the light.
 So we stand from hour to hour,
 between hope and fear, joy and pain.
 Whenever we feel the heart expand,
 we feel it contract again.
 Listen! A strange sound catches the ear,
 borne on the swift-passing wind.
 Listen! It rings again, loud and clear,
 echoing faintly down the valley:
 “Here is rest!” A voice
 breaks the gloomy silence—

Reading note. Continues at 10-126. The poem now stages a debate among different religious voices.

Scan 126 10-126

Hours of Bitterness: competing promises of salvation

“Here is rest! Rejoice, humanity,
 and come to the living fountain.
 Here is a balm for every wound
 that human hearts bear deeply.
 It can be found by faith alone,
 secured only through humble prayer.

Know that by yourselves you are lost,
 totally depraved on earth.
 You have no power to redeem yourselves
 until you experience a second birth.
 But once you have passed from nature's night,
 where you stand doubting hour by hour,
 into the Spirit's marvelous light
 that leads to a better land,
 heaven's glories are your own
 in all their spotless purity.
 Before the great eternal throne
 you will rejoice for eternity.
 This is the way, and the only way;
 all others lead to the gloom below.
 Accept this precious gift now,
 before you taste the second death."

"Here is rest!" Again we hear
 the enticing voice from another direction.
 It greets the ear with melodious sweetness,
 a softer cadence unknown before:
 "Here is rest for you, humanity.
 Free redemption is spread abroad.
 Come and take your glorious stand;
 cast aside your burden of sin.
 Believe that One bore a cross—

Reading note. Continues at 10-127. These are different quoted speakers within the poem, not a single uninterrupted statement of the poet's beliefs.

Scan 127 10-127

Hours of Bitterness: obedience and predestination

"Up Calvary's rugged slope
 to free humanity from sin's dark impurities.
 Believe, humanity: believe and weep.
 Weeping, bow at his command
 beneath the flowing, crystal water,
 then rise clothed in robes of life.
 For this the mighty Savior died.
 On high he stands to plead the case
 of those who claim his favor
 by willingly obeying his laws,
 seeking 'another name.'
 Only this way can rest be found.
 For the many hungry, waiting souls,

false teachers will always abound
while time's tide rolls darkly onward."

Again we hear a different voice
ringing through the murky air:
"Know, humanity, first and last,
what heaven has promised you here.
It was determined from the earliest hour
when creation came into being:
some would rise in spiritual power
and be heaven's chosen on earth.
Saved by the great sacrifice,
they need not fear dark sin,
for through it heaven's paradise
is theirs beyond this world of care.
But some, through the endless night
of misery and dark despair,
excluded from redemption's light,
must bear heaven's curse—

Reading note. Continues at 10-128. The family reading smooths an irregular line about hungry, waiting souls. The theological statements belong to contrasting voices staged by the poem.

Scan 128 10-128

Hours of Bitterness rejects contradictory sectarian claims

"For them no sacrifice was made
through heaven's own eternal grace.
They must bear the curse laid
upon Adam's fallen, erring race.
They plead in vain for life
and happiness beyond the grave
if they are predestined for conflict
and misery in the world to come.
So it is said, and so it will be,
as surely as heaven rules above.
This is the law laid down;
you must accept it without asking why."

Where should we go? Whom should we hear?
Whom can we believe and trust through it all?
Each offers rest from every fear;
each says the other must surely fail.
Where is a ray of light shed
amid the surrounding dreary darkness
whose bright scene another teacher
does not shroud in dread?

“We will leave them: they are all wrong,
 narrow-minded, biased, blind.
 Their brightest creeds are an old song,
 refined into deep sectarianism.
 We will leave them. Their deceptive reasoning
 only leads the mind astray.
 They are true to nothing but hypocrisy;
 they are false in every way.”

February 1867.

Reading note. Conclusion of 10-121–128. The poem criticizes competing religious teachers; that alone does not establish rejection of all faith or membership in a particular denomination.

Scan 129 10-129

Blue eyes imagined during a storm

[[Title partly unreadable, possibly “Blue Eyes”]]

Blustering rain rattles loudly on the roof;
 the wind sighs sadly around the gables.
 As I gaze into the swiftly thickening fabric
 of darkness outside, everything grows dark within.

Then I turn to imagination’s lovely skies,
 where no little cloud dims the blue scene.
 Before my enraptured eyes stretch
 wreaths of beauty, casting a lovely glow over all.

In those imagined visions I often meet
 the angelic gaze of heavenly blue eyes.
 I greet their sweet glances with wild delight,
 a holy rapture filling my whole being.

Affection’s purest, strongest flame then kindles,
 flowing in a tide of the purest, holiest love.
 Again and again in imagination
 I clasp this angel from above to my heart.

Yes, I love that pure, spotless form,
 those blue eyes where the deep soul dwells.
 They are the gates through which a pure, warm heart
 reveals affection’s deepest tides.

I love the noble, generous nature
 revealed in those heavenly blue eyes.
 Though forever beyond my farthest reach,
 I may court that spirit in imagination’s loveliest fields.

February 1867.

Reading note. The title is damaged. No recipient is named, and the poem repeatedly describes an imagined encounter.

Scan 130 10-130

Oh! Let Me Forget: childhood and vanished hopes

Oh, Let Me Forget!

In answer to “Forget? Oh, never!”

Let me forget the early scenes of childhood,
when I wandered carelessly among the brightest flowers:
on hills, in valleys, beside the stream in the woods,
breathing their fragrance all day long.

My young heart expanded in the bright sunshine
that nourished the sweet flowers budding around me,
and breathed in pure feelings of nobility and divinity,
which filled the air at every joyful heartbeat.

Oh, let me forget!

Those bright scenes linger in memory,
contrasting vividly with the dark gloom around me,
like voices of distant, melodious singers
that sometimes reach us with a heavenly sound.

Their mellow sweetness seems unearthly,
as though it came from a holier realm.

The rich bursts of their rhythmic sweetness
reveal the discord always present here.

Oh, let me forget!

Let me forget the hopes I cherished
in boyhood’s bright morning, when everything was fair.

I scarcely imagined they would all perish,
melting away like a mirage in the air.

But they are gone. Everything that bloomed
has quickly faded before my eager eyes:
everything that once so brightly and sweetly lit
my wanderings through life’s dreary maze.

Oh, let me forget!

Reading note. Continues at 10-131–132. The named poem being answered has not been independently identified.

Scan 131 10-131

Oh! Let Me Forget: leaving home and the horrors of war

Let me forget the sad tears when I left
home and its attractions, which I loved so well,
and the dear friends left brokenhearted
when I spoke what I thought was my last sad farewell.

I was going to the war whose alarm rang out
a death knell for thousands in our beautiful land,
rapidly drawing from its farthest reaches

those daring heroes who would withstand the shock.
Oh, let me forget!

Let me forget the muskets' terrible rattle,
where brothers fell fighting brothers,
and the cannon's loud roar amid battle's din,
portraying a miniature hell on earth.
Death rode proudly upon the wind,
fiendishly hurling darts over the plain,
or casting them fiercely again and again
over the dark waves of the swelling seas.
Oh, let me forget!

Let me forget those dark, horrifying scenes
that tormented the soul with dreadful visions,
foretelling that every coming day
would add a new list to the nations of the dead.
The dark robe of crime gathering over us
tormented the sad heart where the gospel's light shone.
With oppression always looming before us,
it prepared us to yield before life was completely gone.
Oh, let me forget!

Let me forget the woman to whom I pledged
the wild, romantic feelings burning in my heart,
and those heavenly bonds that continually invited—

Reading note. Continues at 10-132. This is a poem's account of wartime separation and horror; it supplies no independently verified battle, service record, or partner's name.

Scan 132 10-132

Oh! Let Me Forget ends with grief and memory

My wild, wandering spirit toward sweet moments of rest.
The attractions surrounding her made our parting painful
and sadden the long hours of every returning day.
Too often a pearly tear starts beneath my eyelids,
staining stern manhood's path with what the speaker calls "effeminacy."
Oh, let me forget!

Let me forget the varied past and its pleasures,
which can never, never return in life,
with its hopes, joys, and the heart's deepest treasures,
all now decaying in the tomb's urn.
Like a storm-shattered tree alone on the heath,
far from its companions in the beautiful forest,
I stand looking at my branches scattered low in death
and pour my lament into the wild desert air.
Oh, let me forget!

February 1867.

Reading note. Concludes 10-130–132. The death and desert imagery is poetic; no named person's death is established here.

Scan 133 10-133

A portrait in verse, dated May 31, 1861

She was not very beautiful, if beauty is judged
 by a classical model perfectly at rest. *[[The source's second line is incomplete or irregular.]]*
 She did not look bewitching, if enchantment means
 having a forehead and lips transparent as the sea.
 Her grace followed no prescribed rule;
 her lively sparkle was never learned at school.
 Her words were distinctive, like the fairies' fabled language,
 and her voice was always sweetest in the cadences of grief.
 Did I say she was not beautiful? Her eyes met yours
 with the softly shining purity of planetary light.
 An intellectual beauty, like a light within a vase,
 touched every line of her animated face with glory.

Written May 31, 1861, by *[[Lizzie?]]* Douglas.

Reading note. The signature's first name is tentative. "Written" does not establish original composition: this could be a copied poem. The subject is not identified.